A DOCTORAL THESIS

PER SPECULUM IN AENIGMATE

Deuteroscopy, Anaphany, and the Retroactive Sacred in the Cinema of M. Night Shyamalan

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Abstract

This dissertation advances a unified theory of the cinema of M. Night Shyamalan (b. 1970) organized around a deliberately overdetermined concept: *deuteroscopy*. In early modern English the word could designate both the concealed secondary sense of a text and the Highland faculty of "second sight"; it is extended here to name a third phenomenon native to Shyamalan's dramaturgy, the *second viewing*, in which a terminal revelation retroactively reorganizes every image that preceded it. The argument holds that these three senses (diegetic clairvoyance, hermeneutic surplus, and spectatorial re-viewing) are not discrete features of the oeuvre but facets of a single formal-theological structure, here termed *anaphany*: a manifestation that propagates backward through narrative time.

Reading the corpus from *Praying with Anger* (1992) to *Trap* (2024), together with its satellite productions (*Devil*, *Wayward Pines*, *Servant*), against the genealogies that inform it (Aristotelian *anagnorisis*, Augustinian and Boethian temporality, Auerbachian *figura*, Kierkegaardian repetition and the Akedah, Puritan providentialism, Jungian synchronicity, Euhemerist and Campbellian mythography, Platonic and Girardian theories of the founding lie, Winnicottian transitional phenomena, and the Vedic and Puranic cosmologies latent in the director's formation), the study proposes a method of *theological double exposure*, in which each image is read as the superimposition of two sacred grammars, Abrahamic and Indic. Comparative analyses situate the films against the horror and mythopoeic traditions they inherit or invert: Lovecraft, Blackwood, Henry James, du Maurier and Roeg, Lewton, Hitchcock, Serling, Bergman, Blatty, King, Moore, Tolkien, Le Guin, del Toro, Haneke, Aster, and Peele.

The central thesis is formulated as a chiasmus: *horror is providence seen once*; *providence is horror seen twice*. Genre, on this account, is not a property of the text but a phase of perception. Four modes of anaphany are distinguished (eucatastrophic, demiurgic, akedic, and aporetic) and correlated with a four-phase periodization (anaphanic, kenotic, paratextual,

proleptic) that reconceives the director's notoriously discontinuous critical fortunes as the internal development of a single project rather than its interruption. The dissertation further demonstrates that the oeuvre progressively relocates its decisive revelation from epistemology to ethics: the late films no longer withhold what is to be seen but confer second sight upon the spectator from the outset, converting the question *what is hidden*? into the question *what does seeing obligate*? A final chapter reads the director's self-inserting cameos as a theology of authorship, the figure of a demiurge who implicates himself in the suffering he designs, and traces the transmission of the specular gaze to a second generation of Shyamalan filmmaking.

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Prefatory Note on Corpus, Method, and Citation

The primary corpus comprises every feature Shyamalan has written and directed, the features he directed from others' stories, and the satellite productions in which his authorship is partial but structurally legible. The satellites are cited as evidence of selection and stewardship rather than sole authorship; where an argument depends on them, it is corroborated from the core corpus.

YEAR	WORK	SHYAMALAN'S ROLE	STATUS IN THIS STUDY
1992	*Praying with Anger*	Writer, director, lead actor	Core (juvenilia)
1998	*Wide Awake*	Writer, director	Core (juvenilia)
1999	*The Sixth Sense*	Writer, director	Core
2000	*Unbreakable*	Writer, director	Core
2002	*Signs*	Writer, director	Core
2004	*The Village*	Writer, director	Core
2006	*Lady in the Water*	Writer, director	Core
2008	*The Happening*	Writer, director	Core
2010	*The Last Airbender*	Writer, director (from the animated series by DiMartino and Konietzko)	Core (adaptation)
2010	*Devil*	Story (dir. John Erick Dowdle)	Satellite
2013	*After Earth*	Director, co-writer (story by Will Smith)	Core (adaptation)
2015	*Wayward Pines*	Executive producer; director of the pilot	Satellite
2015	*The Visit*	Writer, director	Core
2016	*Split*	Writer, director	Core
2019	*Glass*	Writer, director	Core
2019–2023	*Servant*	Executive producer; episode director (series created by Tony Basgallop)	Satellite
2021	*Old*	Writer, director (from *Sandcastle* by Pierre Oscar Lévy and Frederik Peeters)	Core (adaptation)

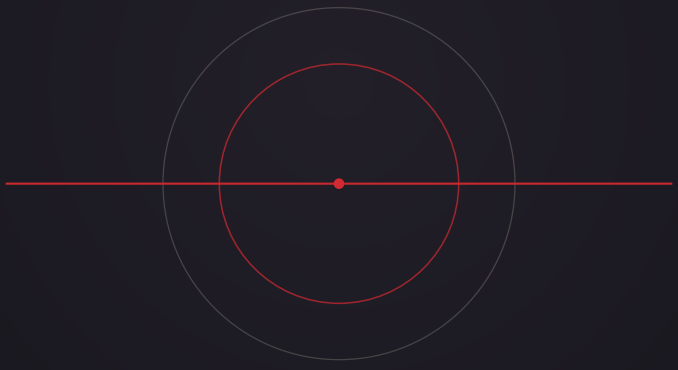
YEAR	WORK	SHYAMALAN'S ROLE	STATUS IN THIS STUDY
2023	*Knock at the Cabin*	Director, co-writer (from Paul Tremblay's novel)	Core (adaptation)
2024	*Trap*	Writer, director	Core
2024	*The Watchers*	Producer (dir. Ishana Night Shyamalan)	Satellite (second generation)
2027 (scheduled)	*Remain*	Writer, director (story developed with Nicholas Sparks)	Excluded; unreleased (source)

Method. The study combines close formal analysis with intellectual history and comparative mythography. Its distinctive instrument, *theological double exposure*, borrows its name from the nineteenth-century photographic practice by which William Mumler and his successors manufactured "spirit photographs": two exposures on a single plate, one of which appears as an apparition within the other. Each image of the corpus is read twice, once through an Abrahamic grammar (providence, typology, sacrifice, the hidden God) and once through an Indic grammar (*dharma*, *avatāra*, *yajña*, cyclical time), on the hypothesis that the oeuvre's peculiar charge derives from the friction between the two.

Authorship. "Shyamalan" designates an author-function in Foucault's sense and an implied author in Booth's, never a psyche available to diagnosis. Biographical data enter only as documented formation: birth in Mahé, Puducherry (1970); an upbringing in Penn Valley, Pennsylvania, in a Hindu household of physicians; schooling at a Catholic academy and then the Episcopal Academy; training at New York University. Formation is treated as a repertoire of available grammars, not as a cause of meaning.

Citation. Films are identified by title and year at first mention. Dialogue is paraphrased rather than transcribed, and analysis rests on narrative structure, *mise-en-scène*, and montage rather than on quotation. Scripture is cited by book, chapter, and verse; classical and patristic texts by their standard divisions; the *Bhagavad Gītā* by chapter and verse.

INTRODUCTION



The Wager of Second Sight

Horror is providence seen once; providence is horror seen twice.

A divisive oeuvre, narrated but unread

Few bodies of work in contemporary American cinema have been so thoroughly narrated and so rarely read as Shyamalan's. Its public history is a parable in three movements: the prodigy hailed by a 2002 newsmagazine cover as "the next Spielberg"; the decade in which *Lady in the Water*, *The Happening*, *The Last Airbender*, and *After Earth* converted that anointing into a byword for hubris; and the self-financed resurgence inaugurated by *The Visit*, which journalism christened a "Shyamalanaissance." Each movement has been told as the fortune of a brand, and the brand has been reduced to two properties: the twist ending, understood as a craft device appended to otherwise conventional genre narratives, and an evident religiosity, understood as sentiment.

This dissertation inverts both judgments. The twist is not appended to the films' meaning; it is the formal correlate of a theology. That theology is not sentimental; it is a sustained and frequently disquieting theodicy that tests, film by film, whether suffering can be redeemed by being seen again. The inquiry therefore treats the oeuvre neither as auteurist hagiography nor as a case study in cultural decline, but as a single, internally evolving argument conducted in images about the relation between perception, time, and the sacred.

Deuteroscopy and anaphany

The governing term is recovered rather than invented. Seventeenth-century English used *deuteroscopy* for the second or hidden sense of a text (the lexicographical record cites Sir Thomas Browne), and John Fraser's *Deuteroscopia* (1707), like Robert Kirk's *Secret Commonwealth* before it and Samuel Johnson's Hebridean *Journey* after, applied the word to the Highland faculty of "second sight." The coincidence of these two senses in one word is the hinge of the present argument, because Shyamalan's films are populated by seers and constructed as texts with a concealed second meaning. A third sense completes the triad: the *second viewing*, the re-watching that every Shyamalan film is engineered to solicit and in which its terminal revelation retroactively reorganizes everything that preceded it.

The dissertation names that reorganizing event *anaphany* (Greek *ana*, "back, again, upward," and *phainein*, "to show"). Where an epiphany manifests meaning at a moment, and a theophany manifests a god, an anaphany manifests meaning backward: it does not add a new fact to the narrative so much as re-illuminate every prior fact, as dawn re-illuminates a room in which nothing has moved. The re-viewer of *The Sixth Sense* (1999) watches a dead man walk among the living,

unseen by all but a child, and thereby acquires precisely the faculty the film attributes to that child. The film manufactures clairvoyance in its audience. This is deuteroscopy in its full, triple sense: diegetic second sight, hermeneutic second meaning, and spectatorial second viewing converge in a single act of perception.

From this convergence follows the dissertation's central claim, stated as a chiasmus: **horror is providence seen once; providence is horror seen twice.** On a first viewing, events arrive as contingent threats, and the affect proper to contingency under threat is dread; on a second, the same events arrive as designed, and the affect proper to design is consolation, awe, or, in the late films, terror of a higher order. Genre, on this account, is not a property of the text but a phase of perception. The same film is a horror film on its first night and a theodicy on its second, and the characteristic Shyamalan affect, the shudder that turns into tears, is the somatic record of the passage between them.

The specular emblem

The title of this study is the first half of a Pauline verse in its Vulgate form: *videmus nunc per speculum in aenigmate*, "we see now through a mirror, in an enigma" (1 Corinthians 13:12). Augustine, glossing the verse in *De Trinitate* XV, observed that *aenigma* names a trope, an obscure allegory; the verse thus already contains a theory of figural meaning, of images that hold a sense their beholders cannot yet read. The corpus literalizes the emblem with remarkable consistency: the infant Elijah Price is first seen in a department-store mirror and the boy Elijah in the black glass of a switched-off television; *Signs* (2002) hunts its intruder in the reflection of a kitchen knife slid beneath a pantry door and finally discloses it in the dark screen of a switched-off television; the director's own cameo in *The Village* (2004) is glimpsed in the glass of a cabinet; the adolescent filmmaker of *The Visit* (2015) refuses mirrors while filming everything; the villain of the Eastrail cycle is named Mr. Glass; and the debut feature of the director's daughter turns on a one-way mirror through which unseen beings watch human captives.

The completion of the Pauline verse is withheld here, as the completion of every Shyamalan image is withheld from its first viewing.

Double exposure and its hazards

The method of theological double exposure requires a caution. To read Indic grammars into the work of an Indian-born director risks the exoticizing reflex that Edward Said anatomized, the presumption that a South Asian artist must be decoded through "his" tradition. The procedure adopted here is the reverse. The Indic grammar is treated as latent precisely because the films almost never thematize it: apart from *Praying with Anger* (1992), set largely in Madras, and the reincarnational premise of *The Last Airbender* (2010), the corpus is set in a Pennsylvania of farmhouses, row homes, and stadiums, and its most persistent South Asian presence is the director's own body in cameo. The claim is not that the films are covertly Hindu. It is that a sensibility formed between a Hindu household and Catholic and Episcopal classrooms produced images that resolve, under analysis, into two superimposed theologies, and that the friction between them generates meanings available to neither alone.

Architecture of the dissertation

Chapter One reconstructs the poetics of anaphany from Aristotle's *anagnorisis* through Augustine, Boethius, Auerbach, Frye, Kermode, Hitchcock, Peter Brooks, and Ricoeur, culminating in the Lucan episode at Emmaus as the paradigm of recognition-and-withdrawal. Chapter Two traces the seer and the psychopomp from the theodical juvenilia through *The Sixth Sense* to *Servant*, reading the films' media (tapes, monitors, footage) as technologies of testimony. Chapter Three examines the grammar of providence in *Signs* against Puritan providentialism, Jungian synchronicity, and the Lovecraftian tradition it inverts, and reads *The Happening* (2008) as its aporetic negative. Chapter Four reads the Eastrail cycle (*Unbreakable*, *Split*, *Glass*) as a theology of vocation, proposing a double exposure of the Trimurti and Calvary. Chapter Five analyzes the ethics of protective fiction across *The Village*, *Lady in the Water* (2006), *The Visit*, and *Old* (2021). Chapter Six reads *Knock at the Cabin* (2023) through Genesis 18 and 22 and the Apocalypse, with *Devil* (2010) and *Trap* (2024) as its satellites. Chapter Seven assembles the theory proper: a typology of anaphanies, a periodization of the oeuvre, a theology of authorship, and an account of the gaze's inheritance.

CHAPTER ONE



Fraught with Background: Anaphany, Figura, and the Poetics of Retroactive Revelation

The Shyamalan twist is the most recent avatar of the oldest device in Western poetics, and its theory must therefore be reconstructed from the beginning. This chapter argues that anaphany synthesizes five distinct traditions of retroactive meaning: Aristotelian recognition, Augustinian and Boethian temporality, figural interpretation, the Hitchcockian economy of suspense, and Ricoeur's second naïveté. Their convergence, it concludes, has a single scriptural archetype: the recognition at Emmaus.

1.1 Aristotle's two recognitions

The *Poetics* (ch. 11) defines *anagnorisis* as a change from ignorance to knowledge that produces love or hatred between persons marked for good or ill fortune, and it prizes the recognition that coincides with *peripeteia*, the reversal of the action into its opposite. In chapter 16 Aristotle ranks the species of recognition. Lowest is recognition by signs or tokens, whether congenital marks or acquired ones such as scars, and his example is Odysseus' scar, identified by the nurse at the bath. Highest is the recognition that arises from the incidents themselves, as in Sophocles' *Oedipus*, where nothing external is needed because the plot's own logic compels the truth.

Shyamalan's corpus runs the full Aristotelian gamut and, more interestingly, hybridizes it. Malcolm Crowe's recognition in *The Sixth Sense* is precipitated by a token, the wedding ring that slips from his sleeping wife's hand, but its force derives entirely from the incidents, since every prior scene has been silently arranged to compel it; the token merely releases a recognition the plot has already made inevitable. *Unbreakable* (2000) invents a new species, recognition by touch: David Dunn's handshakes disclose the sins of strangers, and the climactic handshake with Elijah Price discloses three mass murders. This is the laying-on of hands inverted, a contact that reveals guilt rather than conferring grace. *Split* (2016) returns to the lowest species with a decisive alteration: the Beast recognizes Casey Cooke by her scars, but the scar no longer reveals an identity, as Odysseus' did; it reveals an election. Recognition by sign is thereby transvalued from the forensic to the soteriological, and Aristotle's least artistic device becomes the hinge of a theology.

1.2 Augustine, Boethius, and the temporality of the twist

In *Confessions* XI Augustine analyzes the recitation of a psalm: before he begins, his expectation extends over the whole; as he proceeds, the recited portion passes into memory while attention traverses the present, until expectation is wholly consumed. Time is a *distentio animi*, a distension of the soul across expectation, attention, and memory. The Shyamalan twist performs a violent operation on this distension. At the moment of anaphany, the whole of the film passes from expectation into memory at once, and memory is instantly rewritten: the soul that was stretched toward an unknown end is snapped back across everything it has witnessed, which now reads otherwise.

Boethius supplies the theological vocabulary for that rewriting. In the *Consolation of Philosophy* (IV, prose 6) Lady Philosophy distinguishes *providence*, the divine plan as it exists in the simplicity of the divine mind, from *fate*, the same

plan as it unfolds in temporal sequence; in Book V she explains divine knowledge as an eternal present (*totum simul*) in which all moments are beheld at once, as a spectator on a height surveys the road below. The first viewing of a Shyamalan film is the experience of fate: events arrive one by one, opaque in their connections. The second viewing approximates the Boethian vantage, in which the entire film is held in a single regard and every event is seen in its place. Anaphany is accordingly a *Boethian promotion* of the spectator from the order of fate to the order of providence. The analogy extends to Boethius' most famous argument, that foreknowledge does not necessitate: the re-viewer knows that Malcolm is dead, yet Malcolm walks, hopes, and errs with undiminished freedom. Re-viewing becomes a lay experiment in compatibilism, a demonstration that complete foreknowledge and genuine agency can coexist in one field of vision.

1.3 Figura and the Elohist screen: Auerbach, Frye, Kermode

Erich Auerbach's essay "Figura" (1938) defines figural interpretation as the establishment of a connection between two events or persons in which the first signifies not only itself but also the second, while the second fulfills the first; crucially, both remain concrete historical realities, unlike the abstractions of allegory. This is the precise logic of Shyamalan's setups. Bo Hess leaves half-drunk glasses of water throughout the house; Morgan Hess suffers from asthma; a record-setting minor-league bat hangs on a wall; a dying woman murmurs apparent nonsense. Each is fully real in its first appearance, a child's quirk, an illness, a memento, a delirium, and each is fulfilled in the climax of *Signs*, where water proves lethal to the intruder, constricted lungs refuse its poison, and the dying words become an instruction. Chekhov's principle that a gun shown in the first act must fire in the third is a law of dramaturgical economy; in Shyamalan it becomes a metaphysics, the claim that nothing in a well-made world is idle. The setup is a *figura*, the payoff its *implementum*, and the twist is typology rendered as plot.

Auerbach's *Mimesis* (1946) opens by contrasting two styles that have shaped Western representation. The Homeric style, exemplified by the digression on Odysseus' scar, externalizes everything, illuminates every phenomenon uniformly, and leaves nothing in shadow. The biblical style, exemplified by the binding of Isaac in Genesis 22, externalizes only the decisive points, leaves thoughts and motives unexpressed, and is "fraught with background"; it demands interpretation and claims to absorb the reader's world into its own universal history. Shyamalan's poetics is Elohist in exactly this sense. The decisive fact (a death, a design, an identity) is lodged in the background, unspoken; the narrative claims an authority its surface does not explain; and it demands exegesis. More striking still, the late

corpus stages both of Auerbach's paradigms in successive phases: *Split* turns on a scar read by a beast, and *Knock at the Cabin* on a divine demand for sacrifice issued without reasons. The two founding scenes of Western mimesis reappear, seven years apart, within a single director's work.

Northrop Frye extends the typological insight in two directions. *The Great Code* (1982) reads the Christian Bible as a structure of types and antitypes in which later events retroactively disclose the meaning of earlier ones; *The Secular Scripture* (1976) identifies romance as scripture's popular counterpart, organized by descent and ascent, the loss and recovery of identity, and climactic recognition. Frye's theory of modes in *Anatomy of Criticism* (1957) permits a further formulation. Shyamalan's protagonists begin in the *low mimetic* mode, as a stadium security guard, a lapsed rural priest, a stammering building superintendent, a psychiatric outpatient, and the anaphany promotes them into romance or myth: the guard becomes a hero, the priest resumes his collar, the superintendent becomes a Healer. Anaphany is in this sense a *modal recognition*, the discovery that one has been living in a higher mode than one knew. The modernist critical preference for the ironic mode, which Frye diagnosed as the reigning taste of twentieth-century criticism, partly explains the hostility the oeuvre has provoked: these films are romances in an age that trusts only irony.

Frank Kermode's *The Sense of an Ending* (1967) completes the triad. Human beings, Kermode argues, impose on mere succession (*chronos*) the concordant structure of a meaningful time (*kairos*), as the mind hears "tick-tock" in the clock's undifferentiated ticks. Peripeteia, on his account, is a disconfirmation of naive expectation that, when bold enough, paradoxically strengthens our confidence that the fiction respects reality. The Shyamalan twist is Kermodian *kairos* produced on demand: it converts two hours of *chronos* into a charged and concordant whole, and the audacity of the disconfirmation is the measure of the concord it purchases.

1.4 Surprise converted into suspense: Hitchcock, Brooks, Freud

In his conversations with Truffaut (1966) Hitchcock distinguished surprise from suspense by the parable of the bomb under the table: if it explodes unannounced, the audience receives fifteen seconds of surprise; if the audience knows it is there, the same conversation yields fifteen minutes of suspense. Hitchcock concluded that the audience should be informed whenever possible. Shyamalan appears to be the anti-Hitchcock, the director of surprise *par excellence*, yet the appearance is misleading. The twist is a single payment of surprise that purchases suspense in perpetuity. On every subsequent viewing of *The Sixth Sense*, the anniversary dinner at which Anna Crowe does not answer her husband is a scene with a bomb under the table, and the bomb is his death. Surprise, in this economy, is merely deferred suspense, and the second viewing is pure Hitchcock.

Peter Brooks's *Reading for the Plot* (1984) names the structure on which this economy depends: the "anticipation of retrospection," the reader's forward progress in expectation of the backward glance that the ending will authorize. Brooks grounds the structure in Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle*, reading plot as a detour driven toward its proper end. Freud's earlier concept of *Nachträglichkeit* (deferred action), elaborated from the *Project* of 1895 onward, supplies the darker counterpart: a first scene becomes traumatic only when a second scene confers its meaning retroactively. The Shyamalan film is narrative *Nachträglichkeit*. Its first scenes acquire their full weight, whether traumatic or redemptive, only *après-coup*.

This analysis also predicts the brand's crisis. A body of work that trains its audience in the anticipation of retrospection eventually produces spectators who anticipate too well: they watch every new film backward from its first frame, searching for the concealed fact. The twist, in short, is autoimmune. Its success manufactures the suspicious viewer who forecloses the naive first viewing on which its effect depends. Chapter Seven returns to this autoimmunity as the formal key to the oeuvre's middle period.

The twist is also bound by an ethic. Ronald Knox, a Catholic priest and detective novelist, codified the fair-play contract of the genre in his "Decalogue" of 1929: the reader must be given every clue the detective uses. *The Sixth Sense* honors the contract with scholastic rigor, since after the opening shooting Malcolm never converses with anyone but the child. Fair play transposes into narrative form Pascal's account of the hidden God, who gives enough light to those who wish to see and enough obscurity to those who do not. The Shyamalan film hides nothing that could not have been seen; it merely relies on the spectator's disposition not to see it.

1.5 Second naïveté: Ricoeur and Kierkegaard

The closing chapter of Paul Ricoeur's *The Symbolism of Evil* (1960) describes the predicament of modern belief. The *first naïveté* of immediate belief is lost to critique, and the "masters of suspicion" (Marx, Nietzsche, Freud, as Ricoeur would later name them) teach us to read every meaning as a disguise. Yet beyond critique a *second naïveté* is possible, a believing again through interpretation, captured in Ricoeur's formula that the symbol gives rise to thought. The trajectory maps exactly onto the deuteroscopic cycle. The first viewing is first naïveté, immersion without reserve. The twist is critique: the film exposes its own construction, and the spectator discovers she has been deceived. The second viewing is second naïveté, a re-immersion that is not disenchanted but re-enchanted at a higher level, because the spectator now believes the fiction knowingly and finds it more moving for being understood. The deuteroscopic film is, at bottom, a machine for producing second naïveté.

Kierkegaard supplies the existential register. His journal of 1843 records that life can be understood only backward but must be lived forward; in the same year *Repetition* opposed Platonic recollection, which looks back to what was, to repetition, "recollection forward," the receiving-back of what was lost, as Job receives everything again, doubled. A Shyamalan film offers the spectator what life withholds: the opportunity to live the same events twice, once forward and once backward. The second viewing is a Kierkegaardian repetition, the film given back, transfigured, and many of its protagonists undergo the same repetition within the diegesis. Graham Hess receives his vocation back, Cleveland Heep his voice, Malcolm Crowe his wife's love in the only form still available to him. Ricoeur's *Time and Narrative* (1983–1985) generalizes the point: narrative configuration is a "grasping together" of heterogeneous events into a whole, and the twist is configuration at its limit, the moment when the grasp closes all at once.

1.6 Emmaus: the paradigm of recognition-and-withdrawal

The five traditions converge on a single scriptural scene. In Luke 24:13–35 two disciples walk toward Emmaus with a stranger who, beginning with Moses and all the prophets, interprets to them the scriptures concerning the Messiah. The first Christian anaphany is thus, explicitly, a lesson in typology. They recognize him only in the breaking of bread, at which moment he vanishes from their sight, and they then reread an affect they had felt but not understood, asking whether their hearts did not burn within them on the road.

The Emmaus pericope furnishes the complete template of the Shyamalan twist: a companion misrecognized; an interpretive journey; recognition triggered by a

gesture (a ring falling, a hand clasped, a bat swung); withdrawal at the instant of recognition; and the retrospective rereading of feeling. The pattern recurs throughout the corpus. In *Wide Awake* (1998) the schoolboy whom no one else remembers is recognized as an angel only after he is gone; Malcolm Crowe dissolves into light at the moment he understands his condition; Story departs on the Great Eatlon once her purpose is fulfilled; Elijah Price is lost to David in the instant he is known. Recognition and withdrawal are one movement. The beloved is seen truly only as it leaves.

Anaphany can now be defined formally. It is a narrative event that (1) converts *figurae* into fulfillments, (2) promotes the spectator from fate to providence, (3) converts surprise into retroactive suspense, (4) makes possible a second naïveté, and (5) enacts recognition-and-withdrawal. The remaining chapters test this definition against the thematic architecture of the corpus.

CHAPTER TWO

II

Seers and Psychopomps: Mourning, Media, and the Dead Who Do Not Know

In Shyamalan's cinema the dead are not the source of horror but its patients. This chapter traces how the oeuvre converts the seer's terror into a vocation of care, how its ghosts embody incomplete mourning in both Freudian and Vedic registers, and how its recording media function not as conduits of curse, as in the Japanese horror cycle, but as instruments of testimony.

2.1 The theodical juvenilia

The two films that precede *The Sixth Sense* are usually treated as apprentice work, but they announce the oeuvre's governing problem with unusual candor. *Praying with Anger* (1992), in which the director himself plays an Indian-American student returning to Madras, is the only film in the corpus to set its protagonist inside an Indian milieu, and its title names a posture that the later work will repeatedly dramatize: prayer conducted as protest. The posture has deep scriptural precedent in the lament psalms, in Job, and in the rabbinic tradition of contending with God. It returns, fully realized, in Graham Hess, the Episcopal priest of *Signs* who refuses to pray after his wife's death and whose climactic recovery of faith is preceded by a prayer of explicit hatred.

Wide Awake (1998), released after a protracted post-production, is the oeuvre's Ur-text. A fifth-grader at a Catholic boys' academy, bereaved of his grandfather, undertakes a year-long mission to find God and learn whether his grandfather is safe. The answer arrives through a classmate whom no one else can account for and who is recognized as an angel only after his disappearance. Every element of the mature design is present in miniature: a child, an antecedent loss, a search for a sign, an unrecognized messenger, and a revelation that reorganizes the past. The film's school is modeled on the director's own Catholic education, and its theology is already syncretic in tone: a Hindu-born filmmaker's affectionate, ironic, and finally credulous portrait of Catholic pedagogy.

2.2 *The Sixth Sense*: De Profundis and the preta

The names in *The Sixth Sense* are figural before the plot is. The child is Cole *Sear*, the seer; the psychologist is Malcolm *Crowe*, bearer of the bird that Indo-European, Native American, and South Asian traditions alike associate with the passage of souls. In Hindu ancestral rites (*śrāddha*), crows are fed offerings as emissaries of the departed. The film's double exposure is therefore exact: Malcolm is the crow who is himself an unquiet dead, and Cole is the child who feeds the dead. Hiding in a church among toy soldiers, Cole recites *De profundis clamo ad te, Domine*, the opening of Psalm 130, which the Catholic Office of the Dead appoints for prayer on behalf of the departed. A child prays the psalm for the dead in the hearing of a dead man who does not know he is dead.

The Indic grammar sharpens the Latin one. In Vedic and later Hindu eschatology the newly deceased exists as a *preta*, a departed one who has not yet joined the ancestors (*pitṛs*); unless the funerary sequence culminating in the rite of incorporation (*sapiṇḍīkaraṇa*) is completed, the preta lingers, hungry and

disoriented, in the world it has left. Traditionally that incorporation was observed at the end of a year. Malcolm's liminal existence, which the film marks with a title card announcing "the next fall," approximates the preta's year. The ghosts Cole encounters behave as pretas: they repeat the circumstances of their deaths, perceive only what they wish to perceive, and seek the completion of an interrupted rite. Kyra Collins, the girl whose mother has been poisoning her, entrusts Cole with a videotape that he delivers to her father at her own funeral reception. The rite is completed by testimony.

Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) supplies the Western counterpart. Mourning is the slow labor by which reality-testing withdraws attachment from a lost object, piece by piece; melancholia arises when the subject knows *whom* it has lost but not *what* it has lost in that person. The Shyamalan ghost inverts the structure: Malcolm is the lost object who does not know he is lost, and the film stages a double melancholia, his and his widow's, which the anaphany resolves on both sides at once. When he speaks to Anna in her sleep, releasing her and himself, the work of mourning (*Trauerarbeit*) is completed in a single scene. The twist is not merely a revelation; it is a funeral.

The film's ethical pivot, however, precedes its twist. Midway through, Malcolm advises Cole to stop fleeing the dead and to ask what they want. Terror becomes service. Derrida's *Specters of Marx* (1993) argues that justice requires learning to live with ghosts, assuming responsibility toward those who are no longer or not yet present; Levinas had located the origin of ethics in the face of the Other, whose vulnerability commands before it speaks. Cole's ghosts present their wounds as faces, and his conversion from victim to servant is the oeuvre's first instance of its master transformation: fear converted into function.

2.3 The shamanic child and the psychiatric gaze

Mircea Eliade's *Shamanism* (1951) describes the shamanic vocation as announced by a crisis, an "initiatory sickness" frequently mistaken for madness, through which the elect child acquires the capacity to mediate between worlds and to guide souls. Cole's symptoms, pathologized by his school, by a pediatrician (played by the director) who suspects abuse, and initially by Malcolm himself, are initiatory signs. The film thus stages a confrontation between two paradigms of the anomalous child, the psychiatric and the shamanic, and it decides for the shamanic. Malcolm's conversion occurs when he replays an old session tape and hears, beneath the hiss, a voice pleading in Spanish: the clinician becomes a disciple when the clinic's own recording apparatus testifies against its diagnosis. The Foucauldian clinical gaze yields to the shamanic ear.

Carol Clover's *Men, Women, and Chain Saws* (1992) identifies the narrative engine of the occult film as the "opening up" of a rationalist man to the supernatural, a forced receptivity coded as feminine. Malcolm is the paradigm, and the pattern recurs across the corpus: Graham Hess opened to providence, David Dunn opened to vocation, Elliot Moore opened to an unknowable nature, Eric opened to vision in *Knock at the Cabin* while his husband resists to the end. Lynn Sear's own opening is the most affecting. In the parked car Cole conveys a message from her mother, answering a question Lynn had asked privately at her mother's grave, and the private fact authenticates the medium. William James, defending the medium Leonora Piper, argued that to overturn the law that all crows are black one need not show that no crow is black; a single white crow suffices. Cole's message is the film's white crow, and whether or not Malcolm's surname glances at James, the evidential logic is his.

2.4 Technologies of the dead

Friedrich Kittler's *Gramophone, Film, Typewriter* (1986) contends that the realm of the dead extends exactly as far as a culture's capacities for storage and transmission, and that the phonograph was received from its birth as a medium of the dead. Jeffrey Sconce's *Haunted Media* (2000) traces the persistent fantasy of electronic presence from telegraphy to television, and John Durham Peters's *Speaking into the Air* (1999) reads spiritualism as the repressed origin of communication theory. Shyamalan's corpus constitutes a media archaeology of testimony. Malcolm hears the dead on reel-to-reel tape, in the lineage of the electronic-voice experiments of Friedrich Jürgenson and Konstantīns Raudive's *Breakthrough* (1971); Kyra's videotape convicts her killer; Lynn's snapshots of Cole are marred by luminous blurs, the spirit photograph's double exposure reborn as amateur error; *Signs* listens to its invaders through a baby monitor and first sees one clearly in birthday-party footage relayed by television news; *Glass* (2019) ends with surveillance footage released to the world; *The Visit* is its child protagonist's documentary; *Knock at the Cabin* receives the apocalypse as cable news.

Walter Benjamin named the camera's capacity to register what the eye overlooks the "optical unconscious." In Shyamalan the optical unconscious is a moral unconscious: the apparatus records what the living refused to see. The contrast with Hideo Nakata's *Ringu* (1998), released a year before *The Sixth Sense*, is instructive. In *Ringu* the dead use the videotape to replicate their injury virally, and in Kiyoshi Kurosawa's *Pulse* (2001) networks propagate isolation and extinction. In Shyamalan the dead use the same media to obtain justice. The late-1990s ghost film bifurcated into two media theologies, the cursed tape and

the testimonial tape, and Shyamalan's oeuvre is the most sustained development of the second.

2.5 Comparative hauntologies

The twist of *The Sixth Sense* has an ancestry. Ambrose Bierce's "An Occurrence at Owl Creek Bridge" (1890), adapted for *The Twilight Zone* in 1964, reveals that an escape was the hallucination of a dying man; *The Twilight Zone*'s "The Hitch-Hiker" (1960) and Herk Harvey's *Carnival of Souls* (1962) feature women who have not registered their own deaths; Adrian Lyne's *Jacob's Ladder* (1990) extends the structure across a feature. Alejandro Amenábar's *The Others* (2001), released two years after Shyamalan's film, transposes the device to a Jamesian household and demonstrates how rapidly the anaphanic ghost became a genre.

Henry James's *The Turn of the Screw* (1898) is the master text of hermeneutic horror precisely because it never decides between ghost and governess's delusion; it is the purest instance of what Tzvetan Todorov (1970) called the fantastic, a hesitation between natural and supernatural explanation. *The Sixth Sense* ends that hesitation decisively in favor of the marvelous: Cole is not mad. *Servant* (2019–2023), by contrast, reopens the Jamesian wound and sustains it across four seasons in a Philadelphia townhouse, where a nanny, a household in denial, and an uncanny child keep the hesitation alive.

Nicolas Roeg's *Don't Look Now* (1973), from Daphne du Maurier's story (1971), is the most illuminating antecedent. Its grieving father possesses second sight he refuses to acknowledge; a blind medium sees his drowned daughter; red marks the presence of the dead; and the climax reveals that a vision he misread was a premonition of his own funeral. The Shyamalan palette inherits Roeg's red (a doorknob, a balloon, a sweater, a tent in *The Sixth Sense*; the "bad color" in *The Village*) and its blind seer (Ivy Walker), but reverses its verdict. In Roeg, second sight refused is fatal; in Shyamalan, second sight accepted is redemptive. Stephen King's *The Shining* (1977) offers a second precedent in the telepathic "shine" shared by a child and a cook. In King, the dead covet the shining child as prey; in Shyamalan, they petition him as advocate.

Guillermo del Toro's *The Devil's Backbone* (2001) opens by asking what a ghost is and answers, in effect, that it is a moment of pain condemned to repeat itself. Shyamalan's ghosts share that Freudian repetition compulsion, endlessly re-enacting their deaths, but his distinctive move is to make the seer's service the interruption of the repetition. Where Jennifer Kent's *The Babadook* (2014) and Mike Flanagan's *The Haunting of Hill House* (2018) make grief itself the monster, Shyamalan makes the griever the ghost, and the ghost is not to be expelled but tended.

2.6 *Servant* and the theology of the substitute

Servant begins where *The Sixth Sense* ended, inside a household organized around a death it cannot acknowledge. After the death of her infant son, Dorothy Turner is treated with a lifelike "reborn" doll, and her husband and brother maintain the fiction for her sake; the arrival of a young nanny, Leanne Grayson, coincides with the doll's apparent replacement by a living child. The series develops a hagiography of ambiguous power: Leanne may be a saint, a fugitive from a cult calling itself the Church of Lesser Saints, or both, and her gifts arrive as threats.

D. W. Winnicott's "Transitional Objects and Transitional Phenomena" (1953) describes the first not-me possession, neither inside nor outside, through which the infant negotiates the passage from omnipotent illusion to shared reality; Winnicott located culture and religion in the "potential space" this object opens. The reborn doll is a transitional object deployed in reverse, not to wean an infant into reality but to shelter a mother from it. *Servant*'s radical question is whether a transitional object, sustained with sufficient devotion, can become real, whether play maintained in faith becomes resurrection. Its scriptural resonances are the raisings of sons in 2 Kings 4 and Luke 7, and the series' title cannot avoid the Servant Songs of Isaiah, in which a servant's suffering is mysteriously redemptive. Its Indic resonance is the substitution logic of *yajña*, in which an offering stands in for the one who offers.

The chapter's conclusion can be stated briefly. Across the corpus the dead are clients rather than predators, media are witnesses rather than vectors, and the seer is a servant rather than a victim. Horror is the first viewing of a suffering that, seen twice, demands care.

CHAPTER THREE

III

The Grammar of Providence: Signs, Synchronicity, and the Problem of Correlation

Signs (2002) is the oeuvre's explicit theodicy and *The Happening* (2008) its deliberate negative. This chapter argues that together they establish the two moods of Shyamalan's providential grammar, the indicative and the subjunctive, and that the first inverts the founding axiom of cosmic horror while incurring the gravest ethical objection that theodicy has ever faced.

3.1 Illustrious providences: the American genealogy of the sign

Graham Hess is an Episcopal priest in Bucks County, Pennsylvania, who has abandoned his collar since his wife Colleen was killed by a neighbor who fell asleep at the wheel. Crop circles appear in his cornfield, lights gather over the world's cities, and the family barricades itself in its farmhouse as an invasion unfolds on television. The film is the culmination of a distinctly American hermeneutic of nature. Increase Mather's *An Essay for the Recording of Illustrious Providences* (1684) catalogued storms, lightning strikes, preservations at sea, and apparitions as legible signs of divine governance, establishing in New England a practice of reading events as communiqués. Jonathan Edwards extended Puritan typology from scripture to creation in the notebook posthumously published as *Images or Shadows of Divine Things*; Emerson, mediated by Swedenborg's doctrine of correspondences, declared in *Nature* (1836) that "every natural fact is a symbol of some spiritual fact." *Signs* literalizes the tradition by making the land itself a page: the crop circle is writing on a cornfield.

The choice of sign carries a further irony. By 2002 crop circles were a notorious hoax-form, publicly claimed by two English pranksters in 1991. The film takes the one sign everyone knew to be fake and makes it true, a Pascalian joke at the expense of the knowing spectator. The design of the climax, meanwhile, is Leibnizian. In the *Théodicée* (1710) every event is harmonized in advance with every other by a pre-established design, and in *Signs* a daughter's quirk, a son's illness, a brother's failed career, and a wife's last words are harmonized across years to converge on a single night. Voltaire's *Poème sur le désastre de Lisbonne* (1756) and *Candide* (1759) stand behind every critic who has found the arrangement Panglossian, and Section 3.4 takes that objection seriously.

3.2 Two kinds of people: Pascal, Jung, James

The film's credo is Graham's speech to his brother Merrill, delivered in paraphrase here: people divide into those who see signs and miracles and those who see only luck; the second group knows that whatever happens they are alone, and that knowledge fills them with fear, while the first group has hope. The speech is a secular rendering of Pascal. The *Pensées* (1670) meditate on the *Deus absconditus* of Isaiah 45:15, a God hidden enough to blind those who do not seek and visible enough to those who do; the wager assesses religious belief not by evidence but by its consequences for the believer. Graham's two kinds of people are distinguished not by data but by disposition, and the dispositions are judged by their fruits. William James's "The Will to Believe" (1896) provides the later justification: where an option is live, forced, and momentous, and evidence cannot decide it, our passional nature not only may but must.

The structure of the climax, however, is better described by Jung than by Leibniz. In "Synchronicity: An Acausal Connecting Principle" (1952), published with Wolfgang Pauli, Jung defined synchronicity as the meaningful coincidence of a psychic state with an external event between which no causal connection exists, illustrating it with a patient who was recounting a dream of a golden scarab when a scarab-like beetle tapped at the window. The climax of *Signs* is a scarab moment. Nothing in the film shows a divine agent causing anything; Colleen's delirious words and the night's necessity are connected by meaning alone. The film's theology is therefore not Thomist but synchronistic: a providence without a visible agent, legible only as correspondence.

James's *The Varieties of Religious Experience* (1902) distinguishes the "healthy-minded," who are born once into a sunny faith, from the "sick soul," whose religion requires a second birth through despair. Graham is the sick soul and his restoration is a second birth. The double exposure here is unusually exact. Sanskrit names the initiated *dvija*, "twice-born," the second birth conferred by investiture with the sacred thread; *Signs* ends with Graham dressing again in his clerical collar, the final shot of a twice-born man. The spectator who returns to the film undergoes an analogous rebirth of perception.

3.3 Per speculum: the knife, the screen, and the sleeping demiurge

The intruder of *Signs* is visible chiefly in reflection. Graham slides a kitchen knife beneath a pantry door to see by its blade what is inside; in the climax he first perceives the creature holding his son in the dark glass of a television. The structure enacts the Pauline emblem: until the bat swings, the enemy is seen only *per speculum*. The film's aesthetics of suggestion descend from Val Lewton's RKO cycle (*Cat People*, 1942) and Jacques Tourneur's off-screen menace, and its iconography of siege from Hitchcock's *The Birds* (1963) and George Romero's *Night of the Living Dead* (1968). Its ending descends from H. G. Wells. In *The War of the Worlds* (1898) the Martians are destroyed, in the narrator's words, "by the humblest things that God, in his wisdom, has put upon this earth," namely bacteria. *Signs* substitutes water and makes Wells's providential phrasing doctrinal.

The film's most audacious figure is its author. The director plays Ray Reddy, the neighbor whose doze at the wheel killed Colleen and who now keeps one of the invaders locked in his pantry. Mircea Eliade described, across the history of religions, the *deus otiosus*: a high god who, having created, withdraws into inactivity. Ray Reddy is the *deus otiosus* figured as a man who fell asleep, the author who nodded off and thereby set the providential machinery in motion. The Psalmist insists that the keeper of Israel neither slumbers nor sleeps (Psalm 121:4); in 1 Kings 18:27 the prophet Elijah taunts the priests of Baal that their god must be asleep. *Signs* gives its world a creator who did sleep, then sends him to his creature's door to apologize. Chapter Seven develops this as the first article of the oeuvre's theology of authorship: the author inscribes himself as the agent of the suffering his narrative will redeem.

3.4 The Lovecraftian inversion and its discontents

Lovecraft's "The Call of Cthulhu" (1928) opens by declaring the most merciful thing in the world to be "the inability of the human mind to correlate all its contents." Cosmic horror rests on that axiom: correlation discloses humanity's insignificance in an indifferent cosmos, and knowledge ends in madness. *Signs* is its exact inversion. The invasion from the stars is the most Lovecraftian of premises, yet the climax is an act of correlation, the joining of a dying sentence, an illness, and a habit, and correlation is salvation. In Lovecraft the more one connects, the emptier and more hostile the universe becomes; in Shyamalan the more one connects, the fuller and more benevolent it appears. The oeuvre's cosmos is anti-Lovecraftian in principle.

The inversion incurs the gravest objection theodicy has faced. In *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880) Ivan refuses any future harmony purchased with the tears of a tortured child and "returns his ticket." *Signs* risks Ivan's contempt, for its form implies that Colleen's death had a function: its circumstances supply the words that save her son. The film defends itself narrowly. It never says that God killed Colleen; a sleeping man did, and providence redeems what it does not cause, in keeping with the Augustinian account of evil as privation and the scholastic distinction between permissive and causal will. Yet the form exceeds the defense, because the twist's teleology tends to convert suffering into equipment. This is the oeuvre's deepest ethical hazard, and its strongest later films are those that feel it: *The Village* condemns the designers of a protective fiction, *Old* indicts a corporation that designs suffering for a greater good, and *Knock at the Cabin* makes sacrifice voluntary.

The comparative field clarifies the stakes. Ingmar Bergman's *Winter Light* (1963) presents a pastor who has lost his faith after his wife's death, presiding over an emptying church in the face of God's silence; the first film of that trilogy took its title, *Through a Glass Darkly* (1961), from the same Pauline verse as this dissertation, and its theophany is a spider-god glimpsed by a woman in psychosis. Bergman's mirror yields a monstrous god, Shyamalan's a provident one. William Peter Blatty's *The Exorcist* (novel 1971, film 1973) ties a Jesuit's crisis of faith to his mother's death and treats the demonic as a perverse proof of the divine; *Signs* belongs to this apologetic lineage but de-denominationalizes it, since Graham's God is never named beyond someone watching out for us.

Stephen King's *Revival* (2014) provides the decisive counter-text. A Methodist minister loses his wife and son in a road accident, preaches a sermon renouncing God, and pursues a secret knowledge that culminates in a vision of an afterlife of cosmic horror; King dedicated the novel to, among others, Lovecraft and Arthur Machen. *Signs* and *Revival* share a premise, a pastor bereaved by the road who abandons his faith, and reach antithetical conclusions. Ari Aster's *Hereditary* (2018) completes the triangulation. There every catastrophe in a family's ruin, including a child's death on a road, is revealed to have been orchestrated by a cult serving a demon. *Hereditary* is *Signs* with an infernal designer, and the pairing demonstrates that anaphanic form is theologically neutral: the same retroactive disclosure of design can reveal a god or a demon, and its moral content depends entirely on the designer. Jordan Peele's *Nope* (2022), with its ranch, its siblings, and its entity in the sky, is widely read as a response to *Signs*; it secularizes the sign into spectacle, and its creature devours those who look at it. Where Colleen's last instruction was to see, Peele's gaze is lethal and his sign becomes content for capture.

3.5 *The Happening*: aporetic anaphany and the literalized death drive

The Happening offers no twist. An airborne agent, attributed by characters to plants releasing a toxin against human threat, reverses the instinct of self-preservation in those exposed; the science teacher Elliot Moore opens the film with a lesson on vanishing bees, and a scientist on television closes it by conceding that the event will never be fully understood. Its revelation is the absence of revelation. The dissertation names this mode *aporetic anaphany*: the second viewing discloses not a design but the impossibility of one, and the film's notorious affect (the flattened line readings that critics compared to the 1950s B-movie, the apology addressed to a plastic plant) is its formal symptom. When no design can be disclosed, acting loses its interior and characters move like figures in a diagram.

The film is nonetheless rigorously legible as a Freudian allegory. *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) posited a death drive, a tendency of organic life to return to the inorganic; *The Happening* externalizes that drive as an environmental agent, Thanatos borne on the wind, and returns to the species its own self-destructive relation to the biosphere as a reflex. *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930) closes with the hope that eternal Eros will assert itself against its equally immortal adversary, and the film's climax stages that sentence literally: separated in neighboring buildings, Elliot and his wife Alma choose to walk out into the air toward each other, and survive.

The literary ancestry is Algernon Blackwood's "The Willows" (1907), in which two travelers on the Danube sense a hostile intelligence in wind and vegetation; the cinematic ancestry includes *The Birds* and the eco-horror cycle of the 1970s. James Lovelock's Gaia hypothesis (1979), which describes the biosphere as a self-regulating system, furnishes the scientific myth, with humanity cast as the pathogen against which the planet mounts an immune response. The film's final act, in which a suspicious old woman alone in the woods first shelters and then turns on the fugitives, retells Hansel and Gretel, a fairy-tale substrate that recurs from *The Village* to *The Visit*.

Theologically, *The Happening* is the apophatic shadow of *Signs*. Where *Signs* is cataphatic, knowing its God through signs, *The Happening* approaches the negative theology of Pseudo-Dionysius and *The Cloud of Unknowing*: the sacred, if it is present, is present as what cannot be read. Its coda, in which the phenomenon begins again in a Paris park, figures an eternal return of the unreadable sign. The grammar of providence thus has two moods, the indicative of *Signs* and the subjunctive of *The Happening*, and the oeuvre's theology proves to be not dogmatic but experimental, running the same question through opposed conditions.

CHAPTER FOUR



Svadharma and the Superhero: Vocation, Euhemerism, and the Eastrail Cycle

The trilogy formed by *Unbreakable* (2000), *Split* (2016), and *Glass* (2019) is the oeuvre's theology of vocation. This chapter argues that it fuses an Aristotelian and Gitan account of function with a euhemerist theory of myth, distributes its principals across a precise chiasm of body and psyche, and ends in an image that resolves simultaneously into Calvary and into the Puranic dissolution of a cosmic age.

4.1 The terror of placelessness: ergon, svadharma, recognition

The cycle's axiom is spoken by Elijah Price near the end of *Unbreakable*: in paraphrase, that the most frightening thing is not to know one's place in the world. The claim restates the *ergon* argument of the *Nicomachean Ethics* (I.7), in which the good of any being lies in the excellent performance of its characteristic function, so that a being ignorant of its function cannot flourish. It restates more exactly the doctrine of *svadharma* in the *Bhagavad Gītā*: better one's own duty performed imperfectly than another's performed well (3.35, echoed at 18.47). The Gītā opens with a warrior paralyzed between two armies, unable to act; its teaching is that paralysis is cured by recognizing one's nature and acting from it without attachment to outcome. David Dunn is an Arjuna in a security guard's poncho. He wakes each morning with an unexplained sadness, his marriage is dissolving, and he is preparing to leave his family; years earlier he abandoned a football career by exaggerating an injury so that he could marry a woman who disliked the sport. He has renounced the protector's calling for the householder's, and his despair is the despair of a misplaced function. Kierkegaard's *The Sickness unto Death* (1849) defines despair as the self's unwillingness to be itself; David's cure is consent to being what he is.

The villain's need is Hegelian. In the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) self-consciousness exists only in being recognized by another self-consciousness, and the struggle for recognition structures the dialectic of lordship and bondage. Elijah, born with a disease that shatters his bones, reasons that if he exists at the extreme of fragility, someone must exist at the extreme of invulnerability, and that finding that person will tell him who he is. The hero's discovery is the villain's self-discovery: David's anagnorisis is the condition of Elijah's identity. The film thus grounds the superhero dyad not in morality but in a metaphysics of mutual recognition, in which hero and villain are poles of a single field.

4.2 Elijah the euhemerist: comics as sacred history

Euhemerus of Messene, writing around 300 BCE, claimed in his *Sacred History* that the gods had been kings and benefactors whose deeds were magnified into myth; the work survives through Ennius' Latin version and Diodorus Siculus. Elijah's theory of comics is euhemerism reversed in direction. Where Euhemerus demythologized gods into men, Elijah remythologizes a commercial medium into evidence of men, arguing, in paraphrase, that comics are the latest form of an ancient practice of transmitting history, distorted by commerce but preserving the memory of real extraordinary persons. His theory is also a lay Jungianism, treating superheroes as archetypes surfacing from a collective unconscious, and a lay Campbellianism, treating every hero story as a variant of the monomyth of *The Hero with a Thousand Faces* (1949). *Unbreakable* executes Campbell's sequence with scholastic fidelity: a call (survival of the train wreck), a refusal (David's denial), a mentor (Elijah, revealed as the false herald), a threshold (the train station where he first reads strangers), a belly of the whale (David nearly drowns in a swimming pool), and a return.

Umberto Eco's "The Myth of Superman" (1962; English 1972) identifies the paradox of the serial superhero: as a mythic figure he should be complete and exemplary, but as a commercial character he must be "inconsumable," incapable of the decisive acts, aging, and death that would end the iterative scheme on which the serial depends. The Eastrail cycle dissolves Eco's paradox by inserting the superhero into consumable time. David ages; his marriage falters; his son, played by the same actor in 2000 and 2019, grows from a boy into a man; and in *Glass* he dies. Elijah's gallery is called *Limited Edition*, and the name is a program. *Glass* was released in January 2019, three months before *Avengers: Endgame* consummated the most elaborately serial narrative in film history, and against that unlimited edition it offers a myth that kills its gods.

Alan Moore and Dave Gibbons's *Watchmen* (1986–1987) is the indispensable precedent. It too presents aging, legally suppressed heroes in a realist register, and its villain Ozymandias murders millions by staging an alien attack in order to unite humanity, a design that anticipates both Elijah's terrorism (mass casualties engineered to disclose a hero) and the staged monsters of *The Village*. Juvenal's question of who will guard the guardians, the motto of Moore's book, receives in *Glass* a double answer: a secret society guards the guardians, and recorded footage guards the society.

4.3 The Eastrail chiasm

The cycle distributes its principals across two axes, bodily integrity and psychic integrity, with a precision that permits a structural reading in the manner of Lévi-Strauss, for whom myth works by arranging oppositions and mediating them through further terms.

	PSYCHE UNIFIED	PSYCHE FRAGMENTED
Body intact or augmented	David Dunn, "the Overseer": invulnerable flesh, a single and depressed will	Kevin Wendell Crumb, "the Horde" and "the Beast": augmented flesh, twenty-four persons
Body broken	Elijah Price, "Mr. Glass": shattering bones, a hyper-coherent intellect	Casey Cooke, and the spectator: scarred flesh, a self divided by trauma; the human remainder

Elijah and Kevin are chiastic inversions of each other: a broken body with an unbroken mind against an unbreakable body with a broken mind. David occupies the corner of integrity, which is why he is the hero and also why he is the least interesting of the three. The fourth corner is the human condition itself, the fragile body and the divided self that William James's *Varieties* called the "divided self" and that Paul anatomized in Romans 7. Casey occupies it provisionally, and it is she, not any of the three demigods, who survives the cycle and carries its testimony. The structure implies that the extraordinary are abstractions from the ordinary, three idealized deformations of a human condition that outlives them.

4.4 *Split*: the Horde, the scar, and the theology of brokenness

Split concerns Kevin Wendell Crumb, whose dissociated identities (the "Horde") abduct three teenage girls in anticipation of a twenty-fourth identity, the Beast. His psychiatrist, Dr. Karen Fletcher, argues that people with dissociative identity disorder can alter their own body chemistry from identity to identity, implying that the mind can rewrite the body. The argument is the hinge by which the film passes from psychiatric thriller to superhero origin. Its intellectual lineage runs from Pierre Janet's theory of dissociation (1889) through Morton Prince's *The Dissociation of a Personality* (1906), *The Three Faces of Eve* (1957), and *Sybil* (1973) to Daniel Keyes's *The Minds of Billy Milligan* (1981), whose subject was diagnosed with twenty-four personalities, the closest real analogue to Kevin's number. Mental-health advocates objected that the film reinforces the association of dissociative disorders with violence, when people with these disorders are far more often victims than perpetrators. The objection is substantive. The film's mythic register explains its choices, but a mythic register does not neutralize stigma.

The Horde is organized as a mystery cult. Patricia functions as priestess, Dennis as acolyte, the child-identity Hedwig as oracle, and the Beast as the god whose epiphany they prepare. The cult's sacred geography is the railway (Kevin's father left on a train, and the Beast's epiphany is staged among trains), its offerings are flowers laid at a station, and its victims are chosen for their impurity, which in its doctrine means a life without suffering. René Girard's *Violence and the Sacred* (1972) holds that the sacred originates in collective violence channeled onto a victim, and *Split* stages a sacred founded in exactly this way within a single fractured psyche. The Indic exposure is Shiva as Paśupati, lord of animals, surrounded by an unruly host of misshapen attendants (*gaṇas*); Kevin works in the maintenance tunnels of the Philadelphia Zoo, and the Beast emerges among beasts. The Greek exposure is Euripides' *Bacchae*, in which a god returns unrecognized to his own house and his devotees tear their victims apart.

The film's climax turns on Casey Cooke's scars. The Beast, about to kill her, sees marks of the abuse she has suffered at her uncle's hands and spares her as one of the "broken," whom his gospel holds to be more evolved. Chapter One identified the move as Aristotle's lowest recognition, the recognition by a scar, transvalued from identity to election. Its creed is a vulgarized version of Nietzsche's maxim in *Twilight of the Idols* (1889) that what does not kill one makes one stronger, and it constitutes a theodicy of trauma. Dorothee Sölle's *Suffering* (1973) indicted theologies that glorify affliction as a form of theological sadism, and Joanne Carlson Brown and Rebecca Parker (1989) argued that atonement theologies can sanctify abuse by teaching that suffering is redemptive in itself. *Split* stages the theodicy of trauma and half-endorses it through its structure, since the abused girl survives because she was abused. This dissertation judges it the corpus's most morally compromised anaphany. *Glass* partly revises it: there Casey reaches Kevin not through her scars but through compassion, calling him by his full name to summon the person beneath the Horde, and grace supersedes election by wound.

The final scene of *Split* is the oeuvre's first paratextual anaphany. In a diner, patrons watching a news report about the Horde recall a criminal of fifteen years earlier, and David Dunn is revealed on the adjacent stool. The twist discloses no fact within the story; it discloses the story's universe, retroactively converting a standalone thriller into the second panel of a triptych. Chapter Seven treats this as the inaugural gesture of the oeuvre's third phase.

4.5 *Glass*: Calvary and pralaya in double exposure

Glass confines its three principals in Raven Hill Memorial Hospital under Dr. Ellie Staple, a psychiatrist who specializes in patients who believe themselves superhuman and who sets out to persuade them that their powers are delusions. The asylum enacts what Foucault's *History of Madness* (1961) called the great confinement, the institutional sequestration of unreason. Staple is eventually revealed as an agent of a secret society, marked by a three-leaf clover, that has for generations suppressed extraordinary persons to preserve an ordinary order. She is Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor with the terms reversed. The Inquisitor of *The Brothers Karamazov* rules through miracle, mystery, and authority; the clover society abolishes miracle and mystery in order to keep authority.

The film's central revelation concerns Elijah. He caused the derailment of Eastrail 177, and Kevin's father was among its dead, so that a single act of terror produced both the hero who survived it and the trauma from which the Beast grew. Elijah is thus the cycle's demiurge, a creator who makes through catastrophe. The climax kills all three principals in one place. David is drowned in a puddle by the society's operatives; Kevin is shot by a sniper and dies in Casey's arms, in a composition that quotes the Pietà; Elijah dies of injuries inflicted by the Beast. The three witnesses (Elijah's mother, David's son Joseph, and Casey) then release surveillance footage of the confrontation to the world, and Staple watches it spread through a crowded railway station. Elijah's posthumous claim, in paraphrase, is that the whole had been an origin story.

Read through the Abrahamic exposure, the ending is a Passion. Three men die on one ground, as three were crucified on Golgotha. The prophet is named Elijah, the figure whom Malachi 4:5 promises will return before the day of the Lord and whom the Gospels associate with the forerunner; the protector is named David, ancestor of the anointed king; the destroyer is the Beast, who in Revelation 13 rises from the sea. The witnesses are the first evangelists, and two of them are women, as were the first witnesses of the empty tomb; the third is named Joseph, as was the disciple who claimed the body of Jesus for burial. The footage is a *kerygma*, a proclamation that spreads beyond the power of the authorities who killed its subjects.

Read through the Indic exposure, the same ending is a *pralaya*. Elijah is the creator, who in Puranic narrative is the least worshipped member of the divine triad, a neglect that one tradition explains as punishment for a lie; David is the preserver, who according to the Gītā (4.7–8) descends whenever righteousness declines, and who in Puranic iconography sleeps upon the cosmic ocean between ages; the Beast is the destroyer. Their simultaneous deaths figure the dissolution that ends a cosmic cycle, a dissolution the Puranas describe as a deluge. The

preserver dies in water, and the creator's last claim, that this was an origin story, announces the next cycle of creation.

FIGURE	ELEMENT	ABRAHAMIC EXPOSURE	INDIC EXPOSURE	END IN GLASS
Elijah Price	Glass	Elijah the forerunner (Malachi 4:5)	The creator, maker through catastrophe	Dies of injuries from the Beast
David Dunn	Water	David, ancestor of the anointed king	The preserver, sleeping on the waters	Drowned
Kevin Wendell Crumb	Flesh	The Beast of Revelation 13	The destroyer, lord of beasts and his host	Shot; dies in Casey's arms
Casey, Joseph, Mrs. Price	Image	Witnesses of the tomb; evangelists	Seed of the new cycle	Release the footage

The two exposures do not compete; they superimpose. The linear eschatology of Calvary, resurrection, and proclamation and the cyclical cosmology of dissolution and re-creation are legible in one image, and the film's peculiar mood, at once funereal and inaugural, issues from their interference. This is theological double exposure at its most complete, offered here as a reading the image sustains rather than as a claim about intention.

4.6 Avatar without anaphany

The theology of vocation also explains a failure. *The Last Airbender* (2010), adapted from a celebrated animated series, concerns an *avatāra* in the strict sense: a child who is the reincarnation of a world-balancing spirit and who has fled his calling. It is the one film in which the director inherited, rather than invented, a doctrine of vocation and an Indic metaphysics, and it was widely judged his least successful work. Its casting of white actors as its heroes, in a world drawn from Asian and Indigenous cultures, provoked organized protest, an irony sharpened by the director's own heritage. The film's deeper problem, on the present account, is structural: it compressed twenty episodes of serial television into a single feature, and its revelations were already known to its audience. An avatar story without an anaphany offers the spectator nothing to see twice. The theology of vocation, it appears, must be discovered in the dark to move Shyamalan's audience; delivered as doctrine, it does not.

CHAPTER FIVE



The Noble Lie and the Transitional Object: Fiction as Shelter and as Prison

Across *The Village* (2004), *Lady in the Water* (2006), *The Visit* (2015), and *Old* (2021), Shyamalan conducts a sustained inquiry into the ethics of protective fiction, and because his own medium is fiction, the inquiry is reflexive. This chapter argues that the corpus discriminates between fictions that shelter and fictions that imprison by three criteria (consent, transitionality, and the distribution of cost), and that the twist itself functions as the confession that converts a noble lie into a transitional object.

5.1 *The Village*: Holy Experiment, vanaprastha, and the founding lie

Covington is a nineteenth-century hamlet ringed by woods in which dwell creatures the villagers call Those We Don't Speak Of. A truce is maintained by rules: no one enters the woods; red, the "bad color," is buried; yellow, the "safe color," is worn. When Lucius Hunt is stabbed by Noah Percy, a young man with a developmental disability who is jealous of Lucius's engagement to Ivy Walker, the blind Ivy crosses the woods to obtain medicine from "the towns." The anaphany discloses that the creatures are costumes worn by the elders, who met decades earlier in a grief-counseling group after each lost a loved one to violent crime and who withdrew, with Edward Walker's inherited fortune, into an enclosed wildlife preserve in the present day. Noah, escaped and wearing a creature costume, attacks Ivy and dies in a pit; the elders resolve to attribute his death to the creatures and to continue the fiction.

The Platonic genealogy is explicit in structure. The *Republic* (414b–415d) proposes a "noble lie," the myth of the metals and of autochthonous birth, to secure civic concord, and its allegory of the cave (514a–520a) describes prisoners who mistake shadows cast by unseen bearers for reality. The elders are the bearers of the shadows, and Ivy is the prisoner who leaves. Yet the film aborts the Platonic ascent with deliberate cruelty. Ivy is blind, the ranger who helps her at the wall shields the modern world from her, and she returns to the cave with the drug but without the truth. The escape confirms the cave. The film's logic, if not Edward's stated motive, makes her blindness the secret's guarantee.

Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651) founded the commonwealth on fear of violent death; the elders have built a domestic Leviathan in costume, a sovereign made of masks. Freud's *Totem and Taboo* (1913) linked the sacred to prohibition and to the avoidance of names, and the creatures' designation inscribes the taboo in the name itself: they are constituted by the prohibition on naming them. The circumlocution recalls the Jewish refusal to pronounce the divine Name, here inverted into a negative theology of fear. The community's god is the unspeakable, and its priests are its makers.

René Girard's account of the founding murder completes the reading. In *Violence and the Sacred* and *The Scapegoat* (1982), communities secure peace by channeling their internal violence onto a victim whose death is then sacralized and misrecognized. Noah Percy, the community's holy fool, the *yurodivy* of Dostoevsky's Russia, commits its one act of internal violence and dies wearing the monster's skin; his corpse becomes evidence for the monsters' reality. The victim becomes the monster, the lie is refounded on an actual death, and the elders' closing vote is the Girardian mechanism in its purest cinematic form.

The regional genealogy is equally exact. William Penn called his colony a "Holy Experiment" (1681), and Pennsylvania hosted a long succession of withdrawal communities, from the Ephrata Cloister (1732) to George Rapp's Harmony Society. *The Village* belongs to this lineage but founds its experiment on grief and fear rather than on faith. Its color code was widely read against the Homeland Security Advisory System introduced in 2002, and its sealed world against Peter Weir's *The Truman Show* (1998). Robin Hardy's *The Wicker Man* (1973) is the closer analogue, since its island religion was revived by a Victorian landowner to motivate agricultural labor; so is Shirley Jackson's "The Lottery" (1948), in which tradition preserves a ritual of violence. *Wayward Pines* (2015), whose pilot Shyamalan directed, reprises the structure as science fiction: the last human community is fenced against evolved predators and kept ignorant of its condition by its founder.

The Indic exposure discloses the film's ethical center. Classical Hindu thought describes four stages of life (*āśramas*), the third of which, *vānaprastha*, is the forest-dweller's retirement from household life after its duties are discharged. The elders, broken by grief, have entered a collective vānaprastha, but they have brought their children, who never chose renunciation. A renunciation inherited is not renunciation but captivity. Against this captivity stands Ivy, a blind seer in the lineage of Tiresias and of Roeg's medium, who perceives the people she loves as colors. Her love is the one uncontrived reality in a contrived world. Todorov would classify the film as uncanny, its supernatural explained, but it leaves a marvelous residue that no explanation touches.

5.2 *Lady in the Water*: Proppian functions, conditional joy, and the martyrdom of the author

Cleveland Heep, the stammering superintendent of an apartment complex called The Cove, finds in its swimming pool a sea nymph named Story who has come from the Blue World to be seen by a writer whose book will change the world. A wolf-like creature hunts her, and the residents must discover which of them are the Symbolist, the Guardian, the Guild, and the Healer if she is to survive until a giant eagle, the Great Eatlon, carries her home. The film originated as a bedtime story the director told his children, and its development (including a rupture with Disney and a move to Warner Bros.) was documented in Michael Bamberger's *The Man Who Heard Voices* (2006).

The film is a dramatization of structural narratology. Vladimir Propp's *Morphology of the Folktale* (1928) reduced the Russian wonder tale to thirty-one functions distributed among seven spheres of action (villain, donor, helper, princess, dispatcher, hero, false hero), and A. J. Greimas's actantial model (1966) generalized the scheme. *Lady in the Water* makes the assignment of functions its

plot. Its crisis arises from misassignment, engineered by a resident film critic, Mr. Farber, who identifies roles by genre convention and is killed by the creature for his trouble. The correct assignments are reached by attention rather than convention: a boy who reads cereal boxes is the Symbolist, a man who exercises only one side of his body is the Guardian, and Cleveland, the resident most in need of healing, is the Healer. In deuteroscopic terms the critic dies because he reads with first sight, by the anticipation of retrospection, while the film rewards a second sight that sees persons rather than types. The scene has been read as the director's revenge on his reviewers, and it is that, but it is also a theory of interpretation.

The Blue World's rules are elfland's. In "The Ethics of Elfland" (*Orthodoxy*, 1908) Chesterton described fairy-tale morality as a "doctrine of conditional joy": wonders are granted under arbitrary conditions, as Cinderella may keep her gown until midnight. The creature may not strike once certain conditions are met, and three simian enforcers, the Tartutic, police the law; their number and their kind recall the three wise monkeys of Japanese tradition, which Gandhi famously kept. Tolkien's "On Fairy-Stories" (1947) supplies the ending: the fairy story's highest function is *eucatastrophe*, the sudden joyous turn that offers a glimpse of joy beyond the walls of the world, and the agent of eucatastrophe in *The Hobbit* and *The Lord of the Rings* is the eagle. The Great Eatlon is Tolkien's eagle.

Story stands in the tradition of Fouqué's *Undine* (1811) and Andersen's "The Little Mermaid" (1837), but she inverts it: she seeks not a human soul but the awakening of a human vocation. She is closer to the *apsaras* of Indic myth, celestial water-nymphs who inspire and unsettle sages, and to the Greek Muses, daughters of Mnemosyne, Memory. Her healing of Cleveland proceeds by memory: she elicits his confession that his wife and children were murdered while he was away. Inspiration here is anamnesis. The mythology itself reaches Cleveland only through the bedtime tale of a Korean immigrant mother, translated by her daughter; the film stages the transmission of the sacred into the American suburb through diasporic translation, a second-generation Indian American's parable of a second-generation Korean American carrying her mother's myth across a language.

The writer whom Story must meet, Vick Ran, is played by the director. He is drafting a book called *The Cookbook*, whose ideas will one day inspire a leader, and Story tells him he will be killed for writing it. *The Twilight Zone*'s "To Serve Man" (1962) ends when a benevolent alien book is revealed to be a cookbook for humans; *Lady in the Water* inverts Serling's most famous twist, making *The Cookbook* the benevolent book that saves humanity. Whether or not deliberate, the inversion is structurally exact. That the director cast himself as a prophet

martyred for his words, in a film where the critic is devoured, was received as grandiosity. Chapter Seven reads it as the oeuvre's most exposed statement of its theology of authorship.

Guillermo del Toro's *Pan's Labyrinth*, released the same year, offers the decisive comparison. Del Toro anchored his fairy tale in historical trauma (Spain in 1944), preserved ambiguity about the reality of the fairy world, and ended with a child's self-sacrifice; it was acclaimed. Shyamalan set his fairy tale in a contemporary apartment complex, without historical anchor or ambiguity; it was derided. The divergence maps the critical economy of the decade, in which fairy tale was admissible to adult cinema when anchored in history and ironized by doubt, but the naked fairy tale, Ricoeur's first naïveté offered to adults without apology, was not.

5.3 *The Visit*: Bettelheim's oven and the child auteur

Two siblings, Becca and Tyler, spend a week with grandparents they have never met, from whom their mother has long been estranged. The grandparents behave strangely after dark, and Becca records everything for a documentary she hopes will reconcile her mother with her parents. The anaphany reveals that the couple are escaped psychiatric patients who killed the real grandparents before the children arrived. Bruno Bettelheim's *The Uses of Enchantment* (1976) argued that fairy tales allow children to master existential anxieties of abandonment, separation, and death at a symbolic distance, and the film cites its source text openly: the false grandmother asks Becca to climb into the oven to clean it. *The Visit* is Hansel and Gretel as Bettelheimian therapy. The children have been abandoned twice, by a father who left and by a mother who sends them away, and in the house of the devouring crone each conquers a symptom: Tyler a germophobia acquired after freezing during a football game, Becca a refusal of mirrors that dates from her father's departure.

The film's horror of the aged body (incontinence, nakedness, vomit) is Kristevan abjection (*Powers of Horror*, 1980), and its conflation of old age with madness has rightly been criticized. Its structural ingenuity lies elsewhere. Capgras delusion is the belief that a loved one has been replaced by an impostor; *The Visit* literalizes it, but with a turn: the children cannot detect the impostors because they never knew the originals. Recognition presupposes prior cognition, and the family's estrangement has made anagnorisis impossible. The twist is available only because memory was broken first, which makes the film a parable of the cost of unforgiven kin.

Becca is the corpus's child auteur. She narrates her film in the vocabulary of film school, aims to bring her mother an "elixir" in Campbell's sense of the hero's

return, and sees herself only through a lens. Her refusal of the mirror is a refusal of the Lacanian mirror stage, the infant's jubilant and alienating identification with its specular image. The found-footage form, popularized by *The Blair Witch Project* in the same year as *The Sixth Sense*, returned the director to the means of his own childhood home movies, and the film's production history (a low-budget, self-financed project after a decade of large failures) is itself a second naïveté: the auteur renewed by becoming, formally, a child with a camera.

5.4 Demiurgic designs: *Old* and the Omelas problem

In *Old*, adapted from Pierre Oscar Lévy and Frederik Peeters's graphic novel *Sandcastle* (2010), guests at a tropical resort are taken to a secluded beach where time accelerates; children become adults within hours, and adults age toward death in a day. The anaphany reveals that the resort fronts a pharmaceutical company that brings guests with medical conditions to the beach to observe drug trials at accelerated speed, sacrificing a few to save many. The surviving children, now adults, escape through the coral and expose it.

The film's mythic ancestry is the folklore of time-dilated sacred places. The Japanese fisherman Urashima Tarō returns from the sea god's palace to find centuries gone, and ages instantly when he opens a forbidden box; the Irish Oisín returns from Tír na nÓg and ages upon touching mortal ground; in Puranic narrative King Kakudmi waits briefly in Brahma's court while ages pass on earth; Washington Irving's Rip Van Winkle (1819) sleeps through a revolution. *Old* reverses the asymmetry: a short visit to the shore consumes not ages elsewhere but a whole life here. Its philosophical ancestry is Seneca's *De Brevitate Vitae*, which holds that life is long enough if one knows how to use it, and Heidegger's being-toward-death, which locates authenticity in the anticipation of one's end. On the beach a married couple reconciles, and two children pass in an afternoon through the stages of a human life, including parenthood and bereavement. Keats's "vale of Soul-making" (1819) and John Hick's Irenaean theodicy (*Evil and the God of Love*, 1966), which justifies the world as an environment for the formation of souls through hardship, find their purest figure here: a vale of soul-making compressed into a day.

The twist, however, places that theodicy in the mouth of a corporation. William James's "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891) imagined millions kept happy on the condition that one lost soul on the far-off edge of things lead a life of lonely torment, and held that we would refuse the bargain. Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), which she credited to James, imagined a perfect city whose happiness depends on a child kept in misery; Ivan Karamazov stands behind both. The pharmaceutical company is Omelas's

administration, and its utilitarian arithmetic (Bentham's felicific calculus, Philippa Foot's trolley of 1967) is presented as monstrous. *Old* thereby conducts a reductio of instrumental theodicy: what an audience condemns without hesitation in a corporation, it is invited to ask why it should accept from a god. The film retroactively complicates *Signs*. The director's cameo, as the resort employee who drives the guests to the beach and then watches them through a camera from the cliffs, is a confession: the filmmaker, too, designs suffering and observes it for the benefit of others.

This is the *demiurgic* mode of anaphany: the second viewing discloses not a god but a human designer, and the providential form survives while its subject is indicted. Jordan Peele's *Us* (2019), with its abandoned government experiment of tethered doubles, and *Wayward Pines*, with its founder-warden, belong to the same mode; Aster's *Hereditary* is its infernal variant.

5.5 The ethics of protective fiction

The four films jointly imply a casuistry of fiction. A protective fiction is a shelter when it is consented to, when it is transitional, and when its cost is borne by its teller; it is a prison when it is imposed, when it is designed to be permanent, and when its cost is borne by others. Winnicott insisted that the transitional object is destined to be outgrown, its meaning diffused into culture; the noble lie is designed never to be outgrown. Hans Vaihinger's *The Philosophy of "As If"* (1911) treated consciously false fictions as indispensable instruments of thought, and cinema is an *as if* of this kind. The corpus therefore indicts and defends its own medium at once: the director appears both as an elder guarding the perimeter of a fiction (glimpsed in the glass of the ranger station in *The Village*) and as a bedtime storyteller (the prophet of *Lady in the Water*).

Which of the two cinema becomes depends on whether the spectator is permitted to see the fiction as fiction. The twist is precisely that permission. Covington's elders never confess to their children, but every Shyamalan film confesses to its audience at its end, exposing the machinery that produced its effects. The twist is the confession that makes a fiction ethical: it converts a noble lie into a transitional object.

CHAPTER SIX



The Akedah at the End of the World: *Knock at the Cabin* and the Late Theology of Demand

Knock at the Cabin (2023) is the late summa of the oeuvre. This chapter argues that it fuses three scriptural scenes (Mamre, Moriah, and Patmos), revises the Akedah toward kenosis, and resolves its source novel's agnostic ambiguity into an affirmation that marks the oeuvre's passage from a therapeutic providence to a theology of demand. *Devil* (2010) and *Trap* (2024) are read as its satellites: the first as the corpus's sacrament of confession, the second as the moment the deuteroscopic gaze passes from father to daughter.

6.1 Mamre, Moriah, Patmos: the scriptural palimpsest

Eric and Andrew and their adopted daughter Wen are vacationing at a remote cabin when four strangers arrive bearing improvised weapons: Leonard, a second-grade teacher; Sabrina, a nurse; Adriane, a cook; and Redmond, a utility worker. They announce that the family must freely choose to sacrifice one of its members to avert the end of the world, that they themselves may not perform the sacrifice, and that every refusal will bring a judgment. With each refusal one of the visitors dies and a new catastrophe arrives on the cabin's television. Andrew recognizes Redmond as a man who once assaulted him in a homophobic attack and concludes that the visitors share a hate-fueled delusion; Eric, concussed in the break-in, glimpses a figure made of light. At the end Eric offers himself, Andrew carries out the sacrifice, and the catastrophes cease.

Three scriptural scenes are superimposed. In Genesis 18 three visitors appear at Abraham's tent at Mamre, receive his hospitality, announce the birth of Isaac and the imminent destruction of Sodom, and accept Abraham's bargaining over how many righteous persons would suffice to spare the city. The Epistle to the Hebrews (13:2) draws the moral that some have entertained angels unawares. In Genesis 22, the Akedah, God commands Abraham to offer Isaac, Abraham obeys in silence, and a ram is substituted at the last moment. In Revelation 6 four horsemen bring conquest, war, famine, and death, and in Revelation 3:20 Christ says that he stands at the door and knocks, entering wherever the door is opened. Shyamalan retitled Paul Tremblay's novel *The Cabin at the End of the World* (2018), and the new title foregrounds the knock of Revelation 3:20. Eric's late decoding of the visitors as a human allegory of the horsemen, recast as the capacities to guide, to heal, to nurture, and (in Redmond) to do harm, completes the apocalyptic layer.

The film revises the Akedah decisively. Genesis 22 demands the son; *Knock at the Cabin* receives the father. When Eric offers himself, he takes the place the ram took for Isaac, and Abraham's assurance that God will provide himself a lamb (Genesis 22:8), which Christian typology read as a prophecy of Christ, is fulfilled in a father's self-offering on behalf of his child. The Akedah is rewritten as *kenosis*, the self-emptying of Philippians 2:7, and the film's sacrifice ceases to be the sacrifice of another.

6.2 The door without a handle

William Holman Hunt's *The Light of the World* (1851–1853) depicts Christ knocking at an overgrown door that has no handle on the outside; it can be opened only from within, and the painting's theology is that grace cannot compel. *Knock at the Cabin* is Hunt's painting as a home invasion. The visitors break the door down, but they cannot make the choice: the rule that the family alone may offer the sacrifice is the handle that exists only on the inside. The apocalypse can breach the house but not the will. Its theology is therefore emphatically libertarian in the theological sense: neither salvation nor judgment can be accomplished without free consent, even at the end of the world.

The Indic exposure confirms the structure from an independent tradition. In Vedic ritual the sacrifice belongs to its patron, the *yajamāna*, who commissions and offers it; officiating priests act on his behalf but cannot sacrifice for an unwilling patron. The visitors are officiants and the family is the yajamāna. The *Puruṣa Sūkta* (Rigveda 10.90) narrates the gods' sacrifice of the cosmic Person, from whose dismembered body the world is formed, and Vedic thought conceives sacrifice as sustaining the cosmic order (*ṛta*). In the film the end of the world is the dissolution of order, averted by an offering. In both grammars, what is offered must be one's own and must be precious, which is why the visitors insist that the chosen family be one that loves.

6.3 Kierkegaard, Derrida, James: the genuine option

Kierkegaard's *Fear and Trembling* (1843), written under the pseudonym Johannes de Silentio, asks whether there can be a teleological suspension of the ethical, an absolute duty to God that overrides universal ethical obligation, and contrasts the knight of infinite resignation, who renounces, with the knight of faith, who renounces and yet believes he will receive back. Abraham cannot explain himself in the language of the universal; he is silent. *Knock at the Cabin* stages the problem in its harshest modern form. Andrew is the ethicist, who will not kill and will not believe; Eric is the knight of faith, who believes that the absurd demand is real. Yet Eric's faith differs from Abraham's in that it takes the form of self-offering, and so retains the ethical within the religious. Emmanuel Levinas objected that Abraham's greatness lies in hearing the second voice, the one that stops the knife; Shyamalan's film may be said to grant both voices, since the knife falls, but on the one who chose it.

Derrida's *The Gift of Death* (1992) generalizes the Akedah into the structure of all responsibility. Every other is wholly other (*tout autre est tout autre*), so that responding to one other sacrifices responsibility to all the rest; Derrida's homely

example is that to feed one cat is to let the world's other cats go hungry. *Knock at the Cabin* literalizes the aporia at planetary scale: to save Andrew and Wen is to sacrifice billions, and to save billions is to sacrifice Eric. William James's "The Will to Believe" (1896) supplies the decision procedure. A *genuine option* is live, forced, and momentous; where evidence cannot settle such an option, our passional nature must, because to refuse to decide is itself to decide. The family's dilemma is a genuine option in its purest form. Both hypotheses are live to the characters; refusal is itself a choice, since the catastrophes proceed; and the decision is unique and irreversible. Andrew's skepticism (concussion, coincidence, a hate crime disguised as prophecy) is the rationalist's legitimate defense, and Eric's choice is the passional decision James defended. Pascal's wager hovers above both: finite loss against infinite stakes.

6.4 Adaptation as theological decision

Tremblay's novel kills Wen in an accident midway, has the parents refuse to choose, and ends in sustained ambiguity: the couple walk out into a storm, the reality of the apocalypse undetermined. Its horror is the horror of undecidability, Todorov's fantastic held open to the last page. Shyamalan keeps Wen alive, has Eric choose, and confirms that the apocalypse was real. The adaptation forecloses the fantastic in favor of the marvelous and thereby makes a theological decision: the cosmos is not indifferent, the demand was real, and the sacrifice was efficacious.

The decision marks a trajectory. The God of *Signs* arranges coincidences on behalf of a family; the God of *Knock at the Cabin* demands blood from one. In their study *Soul Searching* (2005), Christian Smith and Melinda Lundquist Denton characterized the de facto creed of American adolescents as "moralistic therapeutic deism," belief in a God who wants people to be good and happy and who intervenes chiefly to solve problems. *Signs* sits uneasily close to that creed; *Knock at the Cabin* leaves it behind for the God of Moriah. Jung's *Answer to Job* (1952) read the God of Job as amoral and unconscious, in need of human consciousness to become fully divine; the God of *Knock at the Cabin* needs human consent to complete its judgment, and the human act is the hinge on which the divine decision turns.

The choice of a gay family has divided commentators, some reading the sacrifice as punishment and others as election. Robin Wood's foundational account of the American horror film (1979) summarized its basic formula as normality threatened by the monster, the monster often figuring what normality represses, including queer sexuality. *Knock at the Cabin* inverts the formula: normality is a queer household, and the threat that arrives brings a judgment. The

film also inverts the long homophobic reception of Genesis 19, whose sin the prophet Ezekiel (16:49) names as pride, surfeit, and neglect of the poor. Here the gay household plays Abraham rather than Sodom: it is the righteous for whose sake the world is spared, chosen because its love is of a sufficient purity to make its offering a real one. That punishment and election are both legible in the film is not a confusion; it is the Akedah's own double nature, in which election and demand are one.

6.5 Against the home invasion: Haneke, Bertino, Darabont, Lewis

Michael Haneke's *Funny Games* (1997, remade 2007) begins with two polite young men at the door asking to borrow eggs; they torture a family, address the camera, and when the mother kills one of them, the other rewinds the film with a remote control and cancels her act. Bryan Bertino's *The Strangers* (2008) has an assailant explain the attack, in substance, by the fact that its victims were at home. These films punish the spectator's craving for meaning by refusing it. *Knock at the Cabin* is their theological antithesis. Its strangers knock, and their violence is supremely motivated; meaning, not meaninglessness, is the terror. Where Haneke's remote control strips the victims' act of consequence, Shyamalan's ending confirms that a family's act has saved the world. The home invasion becomes a visitation.

Frank Darabont's *The Mist* (2007), from Stephen King's 1980 novella, is the precise mirror. It too presents an apocalypse and a zealot who demands expiatory sacrifice, and it ends with a father who, in despair, kills his son moments before rescue arrives, perhaps the most devastating dyscatastrophe in American horror. In Darabont a father sacrifices his son from despair, and the end was already ending; in Shyamalan a father sacrifices himself in faith, and the end ends because of it. The two films are Tolkien's eucatastrophe and its dark twin.

The mythopoeic tradition supplies the positive lineage. In C. S. Lewis's *The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe* (1950), a "Deeper Magic" ordains that when a willing and innocent victim dies in a traitor's place, death itself begins to work backward; in del Toro's *Pan's Labyrinth*, the child heroine refuses to shed an innocent's blood and gives her own. Girard's late theology (*I See Satan Fall Like Lightning*, 1999) held that the Gospel exposes the scapegoat mechanism by revealing the victim's innocence and the victim's voluntary acceptance. *Knock at the Cabin* is pre-Girardian in demanding a sacrifice and post-Girardian in making it a self-offering rather than a scapegoating.

6.6 *Devil*: confession as exorcism

Devil (2010), from a story by Shyamalan, traps five strangers in the elevator of a Philadelphia office tower, one of whom is the Devil. A devout security guard recognizes the pattern from his mother's tales; a detective investigating the deaths is himself bereaved, his wife and son killed by a hit-and-run driver. The driver proves to be among the trapped, confesses, and is spared, because the Devil cannot claim a soul that has confessed; the detective forgives him. The film advances two propositions. The first is Blatty's apologetic syllogism, voiced by the guard: if the Devil is real, then so is God. The second is the corpus's sacramental principle: horror is ended not by violence but by confession and forgiveness. The road death that precedes the action recalls the road death that precedes *Signs*; in both, the anaphany concerns not how the death happened but what can be done with it.

6.7 *Trap*: the father who performs, the daughter who sees

Trap (2024) follows Cooper, a firefighter and doting father, who takes his teenage daughter Riley to a stadium concert by the pop star Lady Raven. Cooper is the serial killer known as the Butcher, and the concert is a trap set by the FBI under the profiler Dr. Josephine Grant. The film discloses his identity in its first act. The twist has migrated: the spectator knows from the outset, and suspense replaces surprise. Hitchcock's bomb is placed under the table at once, and the spectator, like Cole Sear, sees from the start the killer walking unrecognized among the living. *Trap* is the director's most explicitly Hitchcockian film, and its profiler's account of the killer's mother answers the psychiatrist's coda in *Psycho* (1960).

The stadium is a panopticon in Foucault's sense (*Discipline and Punish*, 1975): a structure of total visibility administered by an unseen authority, against which Cooper improvises an anti-panoptic choreography. It is also Erving Goffman's dramaturgy literalized (*The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life*, 1956): the father's performance of normality is a front-stage persona, and the film's action consists of his passages backstage. Against both stands Lady Raven, played by the director's daughter Saleka Night Shyamalan, who wrote and performed the film's songs. The heroine who outwits the killer is an artist who turns her stage into an instrument of justice. Art becomes the counter-panopticon.

The casting of the profiler adds an intertext of rare density. Hayley Mills starred as a child in *Whistle Down the Wind* (1961), based on a novel by her mother, Mary Hayley Bell, in which children mistake an escaped murderer hiding in a barn for Jesus Christ. In *Trap* the actress who, as a child, mistook a murderer for the Messiah returns as the expert who sees through a murderer performing the role

of an exemplary father, and she does so in a film whose heroine, like the young Mills, performs material shaped within her own family. *Trap* is accordingly a meditation on the child's misrecognition of the father and its correction, an anagnorisis of the father. This is a structural reading, not a biographical one: within the oeuvre, the figure of the father-author, who once administered the deuteroscopic gaze, is now subjected to it, and the gaze passes to a daughter who sees.

CHAPTER SEVEN

VII

Deuteroscopy: Toward a Theory of the Retroactive Sacred

The preceding chapters read the corpus thematically; this chapter assembles the theory. It argues that deuteroscopy constitutes Shyamalan's cinema as a secular spiritual exercise whose rule is repetition, distinguishes four modes of anaphany and four phases of the oeuvre, reads the cameos as a theology of authorship that moves from demiurgic guilt to self-contraction, interprets the oeuvre's reception as its own anaphany, and follows the specular gaze into the work of the next generation.

7.1 The deuteroscopic triad as spiritual exercise

The three senses of deuteroscopy are not parallel features but a single circuit. The diegetic seer is a *mise en abyme* of the spectator, in Gide's sense of a work that contains a reduced image of itself: each film installs within its story a figure who already possesses the perception the film will confer on its audience at the end. Cole Sear sees the dead among the living, and the re-viewer of *The Sixth Sense* sees Malcolm. Ivy Walker perceives love as color in a world of costumes, and the re-viewer of *The Village* sees the one reality the elders did not manufacture. David Dunn reads guilt by touch, and the re-viewer of *Unbreakable* reads it in Elijah's every courtesy. The Symbolist of *Lady in the Water* is a boy who reads the backs of cereal boxes, a hermeneut of the mundane; Becca sees the world only through a lens; Eric glimpses light; Lady Raven sees the killer in the crowd. The hidden meaning is what the seer sees, and the second viewing is how the spectator becomes the seer.

The circuit has a precise ancestry in the history of spiritual practice. Pierre Hadot's *Exercices spirituels et philosophie antique* (1981) recovered ancient philosophy as a discipline of repeated practices designed to transform perception, among them the Stoic "view from above," in which the soul surveys human affairs as a whole; the second viewing achieves that view by repetition. Ignatius of Loyola's *Spiritual Exercises* (1548) prescribed, after each contemplation, a "repetition" in which the exercitant returns to the points of greatest consolation or desolation and dwells on them. The second viewing of a Shyamalan film is an Ignatian repetition: the spectator returns to the moments that moved her and finds them charged with a meaning she had felt without knowing it. The deuteroscopic film is a secular spiritual exercise whose rule is repetition and whose fruit is a transformed perception of contingency.

7.2 A typology of anaphanies

The corpus discloses four modes of anaphany, distinguished by what the second viewing finds behind the first. *Eucatastrophic* anaphany, after Tolkien, discloses a benevolent design: a providence (*Signs*), a vocation (*Lady in the Water*), the completion of a rite (*The Sixth Sense*). *Demiurgic* anaphany discloses a human designer and indicts the design: elders (*The Village*), impostors (*The Visit*), a corporation (*Old*), a secret society (*Glass*). *Akedic* anaphany discloses a design that requires consent to sacrifice: *Knock at the Cabin* in its pure form, the martyrdoms of *Glass*, and the dark variant of election by suffering in *Split*. *Aporetic* anaphany discloses no design at all, as in *The Happening*. Several works are compound. *Unbreakable* is eucatastrophic for David, who discovers a vocation, and demiurgic for Elijah, who is discovered as its designer.

TABLE 7.1 MODES OF ANAPHANY ACROSS THE PRINCIPAL CORPUS

WORK	PRECIPITATING LOSS	TODOROVIAN RESOLUTION	MODE OF ANAPHANY	WHAT THE SECOND VIEWING DISCLOSES
Wide Awake (1998)	A grandfather's death	Marvelous	Eucatastrophic	An angel, unrecognized
The Sixth Sense (1999)	The protagonist's own death in the opening scene	Marvelous	Eucatastrophic	A rite completed
Unbreakable (2000)	A derailment that kills every passenger but one	Marvelous	Eucatastrophic and demiurgic	A vocation; its designer
Signs (2002)	A wife killed on the road	Marvelous	Eucatastrophic	A providence
The Village (2004)	The elders' murdered kin	Uncanny, with marvelous residue	Demiurgic	The elders as makers of monsters
Lady in the Water (2006)	The protagonist's murdered family	Marvelous	Eucatastrophic	A function for every resident
The Happening (2008)	The vanishing of the bees	Undecided	Aporetic	Nothing legible
The Last Airbender (2010)	The extermination of the hero's people	Marvelous	None: doctrine delivered, not disclosed	Nothing not already known
Devil (2010)	A wife and son killed on the road	Marvelous	Eucatastrophic	A confession and a pardon
After Earth (2013)	A sister killed by the creature	Marvelous	None	Nothing not already known
The Visit (2015)	The real grandparents, killed before the visit	Uncanny	Demiurgic	Impostors
Split (2016)	A father lost to a train	Marvelous	Akedic (dark) and paratextual	A universe
Glass (2019)	The dead of Eastrail 177	Marvelous after uncanny	Akedic and demiurgic	The trilogy's designer; a gospel
Servant (2019–2023)	An infant son's death	Sustained hesitation	Deferred	Held open
Old (2021)	A marriage ending under a diagnosis	Uncanny	Demiurgic	A corporation
Knock at the Cabin (2023)	A world beginning to die	Marvelous	Akedic	A God who requires consent
Trap (2024)	The Butcher's victims	None (naturalistic)	Proleptic	The father, from the first act

Two regularities follow from the table; a third is held in reserve for the Conclusion. First, the modes cluster by period: the eucatastrophic dominates the

early films, the demiurgic emerges with *The Village* and returns in the late adaptations, and the akedic is the signature of the most recent work. Second, the demiurgic mode is the eucatastrophic mode's critique. It retains the providential form, the retroactive disclosure of design, while transferring the role of designer from God to human beings, and it condemns them without exception. The oeuvre interrogates its own theology from within its own form.

7.3 Horror as the first viewing of providence

The central chiasmus can now be stated with theoretical precision. Noël Carroll's *The Philosophy of Horror* (1990) defined art-horror as fear compounded with disgust at a monster that violates cultural categories, and located the genre's characteristic pleasure in curiosity, the cognitive satisfaction of disclosure. Shyamalan's films are disclosure machines in Carroll's sense, yet their monsters are rarely disgusting, and their dread attaches less to monsters than to contingency: to the suspicion that events have an author, together with ignorance of who it is.

Mark Fisher's *The Weird and the Eerie* (2016) names this affect exactly. The eerie, for Fisher, arises from a failure of absence (something where there should be nothing) or a failure of presence (nothing where there should be something), and it is fundamentally a question about agency: what is acting here, and is anything acting at all? The crop circle is something where there should be nothing; the emptied highways of *The Happening* are nothing where there should be something. The first viewing of a Shyamalan film is eerie in Fisher's strict sense, and the anaphany answers the eerie's question by disclosing the agent, whether a providence, a demiurge, a God, or, in the aporetic case, the absence of any.

Rudolf Otto's *Das Heilige* (1917) described the holy as *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*, a mystery at once terrifying and fascinating, before which the subject experiences "creature-feeling." The chiasmus of this dissertation is Otto's dyad distributed across time: the *tremendum* belongs to the first viewing and the *fascinans* to the second. Horror and providence are not opposed genres but two phases of a single numinous experience, unfolded in time. This is why Shyamalan is a director of the numinous rather than the abject, and it distinguishes him from his contemporaries. David Cronenberg's horror is of the body; John Carpenter's, as in *The Thing* (1982), of a cosmos without meaning; George Romero's of the social order; Wes Craven's late work of genre itself. *Scream* (1996) is the instructive contrast, since there knowledge of the genre's rules is the condition of survival. In *Lady in the Water* knowledge of the genre's rules is the condition of death: the critic who reads by convention is devoured. Craven's metafiction rewards first-sight literacy; Shyamalan's punishes it in favor of second sight.

Linda Williams's "Film Bodies" (1991) grouped horror, melodrama, and pornography as "body genres" that solicit involuntary bodily responses. Shyamalan's films are distinctive in passing from horror's scream to melodrama's sob within a single work, as the anaphany converts the one into the other. The tear is the somatic signature of the second viewing.

7.4 Four phases of an oeuvre

The typology permits a periodization that recasts the oeuvre's notoriously discontinuous reception as the internal development of a single project.

TABLE 7.2 PHASES OF THE OEUVRE

PHASE	YEARS	PRINCIPAL WORKS	LOCUS OF REVELATION	POSITION OF THE SPECTATOR
I. Anaphanic	1999–2004	*The Sixth Sense*, *Unbreakable*, *Signs*, *The Village*	Inside the story, withheld to the end	Ignorant, then a seer
II. Kenotic	2006–2013	*Lady in the Water*, *The Happening*, *The Last Airbender*, *After Earth*	Exposed as doctrine, or absent	Suspicious; anticipates the twist
III. Paratextual	2015–2019	*The Visit*, *Split*, *Glass*	In the universe and the medium	Ironized and complicit
IV. Proleptic	2021–	*Old*, *Knock at the Cabin*, *Trap*	Given early; the question becomes ethical	A seer from the outset, asked to judge

In the *anaphanic* phase the twist operates classically: the decisive fact is lodged in the story and withheld until the end, and *The Village* closes the phase by turning the twist upon fiction itself. The *kenotic* phase is the crisis that Chapter One predicted. The twist had become autoimmune, its anticipation by a now-suspicious audience destroying the naive first viewing on which it depended, and the director's responses were successively to expose myth without concealment (*Lady in the Water*), to withhold revelation altogether (*The Happening*), and to direct inherited properties (*The Last Airbender*, *After Earth*). The term is theological. In Philippians 2:7 Christ "emptied himself" (*ekénōsen*), taking the form of a servant, and in this phase the auteur emptied himself into the myths of others and absorbed a critical abasement with few parallels among major American directors of his generation. *After Earth*, whose young hero must master his fear to become invisible to a creature that hunts by the scent of fear, reads as the phase's self-allegory. Its ethic is Stoic, since Epictetus taught that we are disturbed not by things but by our judgments of them, and Gitan, since the *Bhagavad Gītā* (2.54–72) portrays the person of steady wisdom (*sthitaprajña*), unshaken by pleasure and pain.

The *paratextual* phase begins with a renewal through poverty: the self-financed, found-footage *The Visit*, in which the auteur is reborn formally as a child with a camera. *Split* then relocates the twist from the story to its universe, and *Glass* relocates it again, to the medium, ending with footage released into the world and the claim that the whole had been an origin story. Revelation now concerns the frame rather than the picture.

The *proleptic* phase reverses the original economy. In *Old* the design is signaled early; in *Knock at the Cabin* the question is never what is hidden but whether to believe; in *Trap* the killer is named in the first act. Gérard Genette's narratology (*Figures III*, 1972) calls the narration of later events in advance *prolepsis*, and Wolfhart Pannenberg's theology described the resurrection of Jesus as the proleptic appearance, within history, of history's end. In both senses the late films show the end at the beginning. The spectator is a seer from the first reel, and the films' question shifts from epistemology to ethics: no longer *what is hidden*? but *what does seeing obligate*? Across three decades the Shyamalan protagonist traverses three verbs: Cole's *I see*, Eric's *I consent*, Lady Raven's *I testify*.

7.5 The theology of authorship: cameo, demiurge, contraction

Hitchcock's cameos are signatures, a watermark confirming the author's presence without consequence for the story; Rod Serling stood outside his stories as host. Shyamalan's cameos are diegetically consequential, and their sequence traces a theology. In the mature corpus he appears first as the pediatrician who misreads the seer (*The Sixth Sense*), then as a stadium-goer whom the security guard stops on suspicion of dealing drugs (*Unbreakable*), the South Asian body placed under the American surveilling gaze less than a year before that gaze hardened after September 2001. In *Signs* he is the sleeping demiurge whose doze kills a woman and who comes to apologize; in *The Village* the guardian of a fiction's perimeter, glimpsed only *per speculum*; in *Lady in the Water* the prophet whose book will save the world and who will be killed for writing it. In *Split* and *Glass* he recurs as Jai, a comic bystander; in *Old* he is the employee who delivers the guests to the beach and then watches the experiment through a lens; in *Knock at the Cabin* he hosts an infomercial on the cabin's television, a face on the medium through which the apocalypse will arrive.

The sequence moves from inside the providential machinery to its periphery: from cause (the sleeper at the wheel) and redeemer (the martyred prophet) to observer (the watcher on the cliff) and broadcaster (the face on the screen). Roland Barthes announced the death of the author in 1967 as the condition of the reader's birth. Shyamalan's cameos enact something subtler, a withdrawal whose most precise analogue is the Lurianic *tzimtzum*, the divine self-contraction by

which, in the sixteenth-century kabbalah reconstructed by Gershom Scholem (*Major Trends in Jewish Mysticism*, 1941), God withdraws to make room for a world. The author contracts to make room for the agency of others and, in the late phase, for the agency of a daughter.

The Indic exposure offers a complementary figure. The *Puruṣa Sūkta* imagines the cosmic Person dismembered so that his parts become the world, and the Shyamalan author is distributed across his creatures as sleeper, warden, prophet, and watcher. The vocabulary of Vedānta completes the analogy. The film is *māyā*, projected appearance; the twist confers *viveka*, the discriminating knowledge that sees appearance as appearance; and the second viewing is the enjoyment of *līlā*, divine play, knowingly as play.

The theology of authorship carries a confession. The corpus increasingly indicts those who design the suffering of others (the elders, Elijah, the clover society, a pharmaceutical company), and a filmmaker designs suffering by profession. The cameos are where the author pleads guilty: Ray Reddy apologizes, the ranger guards a lie, the employee watches an experiment he facilitates. In *Lady in the Water* the author dies for his book, and in *Knock at the Cabin* a father dies for the world. The theology culminates in atonement understood etymologically, as at-one-ment: the reconciliation of the designer with those he designed.

7.6 The reception as anaphany

The oeuvre's critical history has the structure of one of its films: early promise, a fall, and a late turn that retroactively reorganizes the failures as necessary phases. The so-called Shyamalanaissance was a collective second viewing, in which critics and audiences returned to derided films, above all *Lady in the Water* and *The Happening*, and found in them, in sincerity or in camp, a coherence they had missed. The culture performed upon the oeuvre the second naïveté that the oeuvre performs upon its spectators. *Lady in the Water* had prophesied its own reception by staging the death of a critic who read by convention, allegorizing the conditions of its own reading in the sense Paul de Man gave that phrase in *Allegories of Reading* (1979).

This dissertation is itself an instance of the phenomenon it describes, and it owes its reader an acknowledgment of the hazard. In 1958 the psychiatrist Klaus Conrad coined *apophenia* for the perception of meaningful connections among unrelated things, a symptom he observed in incipient psychosis. Deuteroscopy and apophenia are neighbors. Graham Hess's speech about two kinds of people concerns the choice between them, and the critic who finds signs everywhere risks becoming Graham before his conversion or, worse, Mr. Farber. The criterion

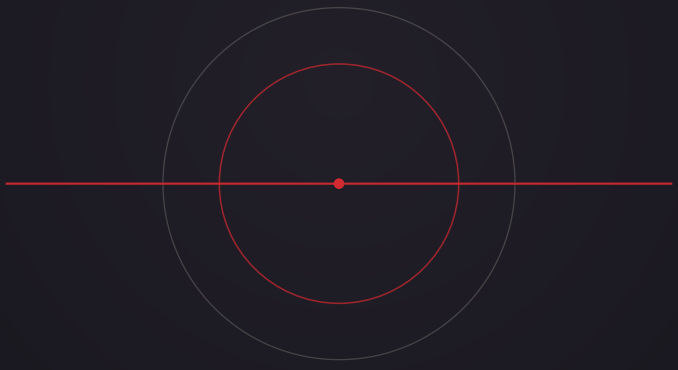
that separates them is the fair-play contract of Chapter One: deuteroscopy perceives connections that were placed, while apophenia invents them. Where this study has proposed readings that exceed demonstrable intention, such as the Trimurti of *Glass* or the preta of *The Sixth Sense*, it has offered them as readings the image sustains, and invites the reader to test them by the only method the oeuvre endorses: a second viewing.

7.7 The inheritance of the gaze

The specular emblem passes to a second generation. Ishana Night Shyamalan, who wrote and directed episodes of *Servant*, made her feature debut with *The Watchers* (2024), produced by her father and adapted from A. M. Shine's novel. A young woman lost in a forest in the west of Ireland takes refuge in a concrete shelter one wall of which is a vast mirror; each night unseen creatures watch the human captives through it, and the captives must stand in view of watchers they cannot see. The founding image of the father's oeuvre, *per speculum in aenigmate*, becomes the founding image of the daughter's, seen from the other side of the glass: the humans are the observed, and the watcher of *Old* has become the watched. In the same year Saleka Night Shyamalan played the artist who sees the killer in *Trap*, performing songs of her own composition.

The child seers of the father's films (Cole, Joseph, Morgan and Bo, Becca and Tyler, Wen, Riley) are succeeded by children who make films. Chapter Six read Hayley Mills's presence in *Trap* as an intertext of dynastic authorship, and the latest work extends the same structure. The observation is structural, not biographical. On the evidence of the late corpus, "Shyamalan" designates less a single author-function than a lineage and a workshop, Blinding Edge Pictures, across which the deuteroscopic gaze is transmitted, inverted, and returned. The seer has grown up and turned the camera around.

CONCLUSION



Facie ad Faciem

videmus nunc per speculum in aenigmate, tunc autem facie ad faciem

1 CORINTHIANS 13:12

The verse whose first half gives this dissertation its title continues: *tunc autem facie ad faciem; nunc cognosco ex parte, tunc autem cognoscam sicut et cognitus sum*, "but then face to face; now I know in part, but then I shall know even as I am known" (1 Corinthians 13:12). The study withheld the second half of the verse as the films withhold the second half of their meaning, and its completion is the dissertation's own anaphany.

Return to the Abstract. It names seers and sacrifices, gods and demiurges, protective fictions, and the traditions from Aristotle to the Purāṇas that inform them, but it nowhere names death; the words *death*, *grief*, *mourning*, and *ghost* do not occur in it. Return also to the second column of Table 7.1, given the deliberately neutral heading "Precipitating loss," and read down it: a grandfather; the protagonist himself; a trainload of passengers; a wife; the elders' murdered kin; a family; the bees; a people; a wife and son; a sister; two grandparents; a father; the dead of a derailment; an infant son; a marriage under sentence; a world; the victims of a killer. Every work in the table begins after a loss, and in all but one the loss is a death already accomplished; in *Old* it is a death foretold. The clue lay in plain sight, under the fair-play contract of Chapter One, and a first reading was disposed not to see it.

The hidden center of the oeuvre is therefore neither the twist, nor the monster, nor the god, but the *antecedent death*. Each film begins after a death that its protagonist has not yet seen, because it has not been mourned, has not been understood, or, in Malcolm Crowe's case, has not been noticed; and each anaphany is the moment at which that death is finally seen. *The Sixth Sense* is accordingly not one film among others but the key to the whole. Every Shyamalan protagonist is in some measure Malcolm Crowe, living in a world whose central fact is a death he has not perceived. Graham Hess has seen only the senselessness of his wife's death, never its shape; David Dunn has not yet asked what it means that he alone walked out of the wreck; the elders built a village so as never to see their dead again; Cleveland Heep cannot speak the loss of his family; Kevin Wendell Crumb's household of selves keeps vigil among the trains on which his father left; Dorothy Turner cradles a doll.

Deuteroscopy, it now appears, is the work of mourning performed as form. Freud's mourner tests reality piece by piece until the lost object can be released; the Shyamalan spectator re-views the film image by image until its central death can be seen and let go. The second viewing is a vigil. The chiasmus that has governed this study must accordingly be completed by its middle term: **horror is providence seen once; providence is horror seen twice; and the passage between the first viewing and the second is grief.**

The pattern extends beyond the corpus into work not yet seen. *Remain*, moved from October 2026 to February 2027 (source), follows a New York architect who travels to Cape Cod after treatment for depression, still mourning the death of his sister (source). Its genesis recapitulates the oeuvre's origin. Nicholas Sparks once suggested that Shyamalan be approached to rewrite the screenplay of *The Notebook*, and Shyamalan declined in order to make *The Sixth Sense*. A quarter-century later the two developed *Remain* together as a supernatural love story, and James Newton Howard, who scored every film of the first two phases, returned to score it (source). The oeuvre returns to the fork at which its ghost story and its love story parted. Whether *Remain* becomes the corpus's next anaphany must await its first viewing, and its second.

The verse's final clause names the reciprocity toward which the oeuvre has always moved: to know as one is known. Face-to-face knowledge is mutual recognition. It is Hegel's *Anerkennung*, Levinas's face, and, in the Indic exposure, *darśan*, the auspicious sight in which, as Diana Eck's study of the practice (1981) describes, the devotee sees the deity and is seen in return. Colleen Hess's dying instruction that her husband should *see* was, in this light, a petition for darśan. The black glass of the films has always looked back: the dark television in which the boy Elijah meets his own face, the blank screen in which Graham finds the creature holding his son, the mirror through which the daughter's watchers keep their vigil. To see a Shyamalan film twice is to discover that one has been seen by it: that the first viewing was itself an object of design, one's ignorance anticipated and one's tears provided for. The spectator who returns is known.

The contribution claimed here is fourfold: a recovered term, *deuteroscopy*, and a coined one, *anaphany*, for a structure that criticism has treated as a device; a chiasmus that reconceives horror and providence as phases of a single perception; a typology and periodization that render the oeuvre's discontinuities intelligible; and a method, theological double exposure, that reads a diasporic sensibility without reducing it to origin. The limitations are proportionate. The Indic readings remain hypotheses that the images sustain rather than intentions that documents confirm; *Servant* and the second-generation films warrant study in their own right; and the claims about spectatorship invite empirical work on how audiences actually rewatch.

Now we see *per speculum*, *in aenigmate*. The films promise only that we shall see again. That promise, more than any twist, monster, or god, is the oeuvre's deepest claim: that what has been lost may be seen a second time and, being seen, released. *Tunc autem facie ad faciem.*

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Keywords

M. Night Shyamalan; *deuteroscopy*; *anaphany*; *second sight*; *retroactive revelation*; *twist ending*; *anagnorisis*; *peripeteia*; *figura*; *typology*; *providence*; *theodicy*; *synchronicity*; *the numinous*; *eerie*; *Akedah*; *sacrifice*; *kenosis*; *svadharma*; *avatāra*; *pralaya*; *theological double exposure*; *euhemerism*; *superhero mythology*; *noble lie*; *transitional object*; *hauntology*; *mourning*; *media archaeology*; *cosmic horror*; *eucatastrophe*; *second naïveté*; *auteur theory*; *theology of authorship*; *Hindu–Christian syncretism*; *South Asian diaspora*; *American horror cinema*; *reception history*.

TUNC AUTEM FACIE AD FACIEM

Horror is providence seen once; providence is horror seen twice; and the passage between the first viewing and the second is grief.

1 CORINTHIANS 13:12